



THE
MEME
THAT
CHANGES
YOU

A viral image turns
viewers into something else.

12matt3r



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The First Time You Watch

The message landed with a dull ping that cut through Mara's living room like a snapped string. Her phone screen lit the coffee table, the mug rings, the edge of her couch where the throw blanket always slipped. Outside her apartment window, the city kept moving - car tires hissing on wet asphalt, a distant siren sliding past and fading - but inside, everything narrowed to the rectangle of light.

Ethan from accounting stood on her lock screen in a thumbnail photo, smiling like he'd just won something. The text under it was simple. a meme link. try it. it's dumb, he'd added. then, as if he couldn't help himself: but don't say i didn't warn you.

Mara frowned at the link until her phone vibrated again, like it was impatient. Her thumb hovered. Curiosity had been her weak spot for years - small, harmless curiosities that made her laugh at coworkers' stupid jokes instead of asking questions. She told herself it was another prank like the ones that had died in a day. A click, a laugh, a shrug.

The room warmed with the glow as she tapped.

The meme loaded in a loop, so fast it felt like it had been waiting. A grainy video filled her screen: a close-up of someone's face, too sharp and too close, then a glitch - like the camera had blinked - and the chat overlay began to sprint across the bottom. usernames, emotes, laughing faces, "no way" and "do it again" and "bro my cheeks - " all stacked together until her eyes struggled to find ground.

Mara sat back without meaning to. The person on her phone blinked. Their mouth moved, and the sound came through a half-second delay, tinny and warped. "It's just - " the audio stuttered, then the clip reset with a hard, cheerful snap.

Her living room seemed suddenly louder, as if the livestream had dragged noise into the physical space with it. The screen kept replaying. The chat kept streaming. Her own reflection in the dark glass of her TV - across the room - held still, a pale shape edged by curtains.

Ethan had said don't warn you, but he hadn't said what he'd meant by it.

Mara leaned forward, phone held in both hands. "Okay," she muttered, though no one was listening. "What's the trick?"

The meme was simple on the surface. A face. A loop. A flood of reactions. But as the clip replayed, the glitches didn't land the same way twice. The lighting on the person's skin shifted, as if a lamp had been moved. Their eyes looked slightly different - one blinked too long, then the reset yanked it back into place. Mara told herself it was compression artifacts, a shitty filter, the kind of digital nonsense that made people swear their phones were haunted.

Then she noticed the first thing that didn't belong to the video.

Her thumbnail reflection in the phone glass - her own face, faint and doubled - flickered at the edges. Not in the way a camera catches a hand moving. In the way a mirror catches a thought, briefly out of sync.

Mara's breath slowed. She lifted the phone closer, angling it, trying to catch the flicker before it vanished. Her reflection stayed there, but her expression didn't match what she felt herself doing. Her mouth looked a fraction more relaxed than she remembered. Her brows sat differently, like she'd been surprised longer ago than she'd lived it.

"Ethan," she said, voice suddenly too small in her apartment. She typed a reply and deleted it. Typed again. Finally: what is this?

The livestream chat answered before Ethan could. Messages blasted across her screen, crowding the bottom of the video like people packed into a room that didn't have enough air.

"Bro my face is doing it too" "stop watching it's contagious" "LOL it's just a filter" "i swear i look different" "no you don't" "yes i do."

Mara's throat tightened. She turned her phone slightly toward the lamp so the light hit her face more directly, then glanced away to her TV reflection. Her living room lights were steady: the lamp's warm pool, the overhead's hum, the quiet of her books on the shelf. Her reflection in the TV showed her the same room, the same angle.

Except her face looked - wrong. Not grotesque. Not changed into a monster. Just... offset. Like someone had adjusted a slider by a hair's breadth and never admitted it.

She blinked hard. The reflection blinked back.

A notification buzzed again. Ethan: u watching? lol. it's like that thing where the meme makes your face "rearrange." it's fake.

Mara stared until the words blurred. "Fake," she whispered, and the word tasted like metal.

She tried to force a laugh, because that was what she did when she didn't want fear to have a seat at the table. "Okay. Cute. I'm not - " She stopped mid-sentence as the livestream audio shifted. The warped voice on her phone said something she couldn't make out, then the video snapped back to the close-up with the same glitchy cheer.

Chat flooded faster.

"WAIT ITS HAPPENING FAST" "mine started in like ten seconds" "i closed it and it kept going" "same" "i can't tell if i'm lying to myself" "bro get a mirror"

Mara's hands felt slightly clumsy, like her fingers had lost a degree of certainty about where they were. She stood, chair legs whispering over hardwood, and crossed to the hallway mirror she'd used to fix her hair before work. The mirror was tall and slightly warped at the edges. It always made her look like a thinner version of herself.

Tonight, the warp seemed sharper, the distortion more deliberate. The room behind her was dim enough that the mirror pulled in light from the phone, turning her skin into something pale and flat.

Her face in the glass looked like hers - until it didn't. Her eyes were too close together by a hair. Her smile line seemed shifted upward, as if her mouth had been trained into a different habit. She lifted her hand and pressed her fingertips to her cheek.

Skin met skin. The texture was real. The warmth under her fingers was real. But the shape beneath her touch didn't line up with the memory of her own face. She could feel the firmness of her cheekbone, the smoothness of her skin, yet her brain insisted it was in a different place.

The livestream kept playing in the other room. The sound traveled back through the apartment as if someone had left a radio on at the wrong station - chat bursts, someone laughing, the warped voice resetting.

Mara backed away from the mirror, heart thudding in her chest like it was trying to break free. She grabbed her phone, thumb hovering over the screen, ready to close the livestream. The chat didn't stop. It sped up, as if it sensed she might leave.

"Come on," she said, trying to sound steady. "This is a joke."

The video replayed again. Close-up. Glitch. Reset.

This time, the person on her phone - whoever they were - looked directly into the camera with an expression that didn't fit the rest of the meme. Their pupils seemed to adjust, as if tracking the room Mara was in. Their mouth moved, slow and deliberate, and when the audio finally came through clearly enough to understand, it wasn't laughter at all.

"Don't close it," the voice said, flat and wrong, like a warning recorded and looped too many times. Then the clip snapped back to the start and the chat exploded with new messages.

"why is it talking" "bro that's not part of the meme" "it's responding" "i'm serious i'm serious i'm serious"

Mara's skin prickled. She spun back toward her living room, phone clutched like a hot coal. The chat overlay crawled across the bottom of the screen, so dense she could barely read her own fear in the words.

She tried to exit. The button didn't respond the first time. She pressed again, harder, the way she'd pressed elevator buttons when the building's system was glitching. The screen flashed white for a beat, then returned to the livestream - same close-up, same glitch, same unstoppable chat.

A new comment surfaced near the top, bigger than the others, as if the meme wanted her to see it.

"it already started" "you can't pause it" "mirror lies" "stop looking" "look closer"

Mara's pulse jumped. She set the phone down on the coffee table and fumbled for her laptop, thinking maybe the link behaved differently elsewhere, thinking maybe she could find the origin, the explanation. The laptop woke with a dull click, the keys cool under her fingertips, but the screen showed only her own reflection in the dark glass until she opened a browser - and then the same link was already there, pinned like it had been waiting for her to remember it.

Her browser history suggested she'd watched it before.

She stared at the timestamp. Her own name sat in a log of activity she hadn't done.

"No," she breathed. The word wasn't for the laptop. It was for her brain, for the way it was already betraying her with tiny inconsistencies. She clicked the tab anyway, as if denial could be negotiated with.

The livestream loaded on the laptop with a delay that felt like a heartbeat. Chat text scrolled across the screen, but the speed changed when she glanced away. The close-up face on the video glitched, and when it stabilized for a second, the person on the screen looked... more like Mara than she wanted to consider.

Not identical. Not a copy. Close enough to make her stomach turn.

Mara crossed back to the hallway mirror, phone in hand again, and this time she made herself look without flinching. She watched her own face as if it belonged to someone else. Watched for the moment it would become undeniable.

Her reflection held her gaze.

Then her left eyelid lowered a fraction slower than her right. She saw it happen in the mirror before she felt it. The skin around her eye tightened, and her eye shape changed subtly, widening as if something in her face had slid into a new arrangement.

Mara's hand rose again, trembling, and she touched her eyelid. The texture was normal. The warmth was normal. But the shape under her fingers was not what she expected from the way she remembered blinking.

A sound came from the living room - her phone, not her, playing the meme's reset. The chat spiked with new messages, and the words felt suddenly personal, aimed at the exact panic clogging her throat.

"mine changed when i checked the mirror" "don't move too fast" "it learns your angles" "it keeps going even offscreen"

Mara yanked her phone up, desperate for control. She swiped across the screen, hunting for a way out, and finally she found a new button that hadn't been there before, a small icon in the corner like an escape hatch.

She tapped it.

The livestream flickered. The close-up face blurred, then resolved into a different frame. For one breath, the chat went silent, as if the room had been cleared. Mara's ears rang with the absence.

Then the livestream camera panned - no, the video glitched into a view of her own apartment.

Her living room. Her coffee table. The lamp. The hallway mirror she stood in front of. The camera angle was wrong by a few degrees, as if the footage was taken from just behind her eyes.

The chat returned, frantic.

"THAT'S HER" "it's in her place" "oh god oh god" "stop watching stop watching" "where did it get that angle"

Mara's mouth went dry. The phone screen showed her reflection from a perspective she couldn't physically occupy. In the livestream image, her face looked fractionally different - older in the cheek, tightened at the corners of her eyes. Not a random glitch now. A consistent change, persistent enough to be captured by a camera that wasn't in her room.

Her phone vibrated so hard it made her fingers ache.

Ethan sent another message: u good? lol. i'm getting scared now. did it do anything to you?

Mara stared at the words until the letters seemed to shift, lining up wrong. She typed: it's on my screen. my reflection - Her reply never sent. The keyboard vanished, replaced by a full-screen version of the meme, the close-up face

filling everything. The person on the video smiled like they were pleased she'd finally stopped pretending it was harmless.

"Keep watching," the warped audio whispered. It didn't sound like a recording anymore. It sounded like someone speaking through a speaker that had learned her apartment's acoustics.

Mara's hands went cold. She understood in a flash that the meme didn't just play. It followed.

She didn't have time to argue with her own fear. She grabbed the phone with both hands and turned off the screen, pressing the power button until it forced itself black. The apartment dimmed, her reflection in the hallway mirror suddenly clearer, just a woman in soft light.

For half a second, relief flooded her. The chat noise was gone. The tinny audio vanished.

Then the mirror shimmered.

Her face in the glass didn't blur the way a screen does when it's buffering. It changed like a living thing adjusting to a new position. Her expression tightened, lips pressing into a shape she hadn't chosen. Her eyes narrowed slightly, the eyelids settling into a different geometry.

Mara jerked back so hard her shoulder hit the wall. The mirror caught her movement and held it, unwavering. She felt a wetness behind her eyes and didn't know if it was tears or sweat.

She raised her hand again, slow, and watched her reflection match the motion a beat later than it should have. Not by much. Enough to make her stomach drop.

A faint sound came from somewhere inside her apartment - like the whisper of a livestream still running, even though the phone was dead. It wasn't loud. It was intimate, like someone speaking from the other side of a closed door.

Mara grabbed her phone charger and yanked the cable from the outlet, then pressed the power button again as if it could undo what had already happened. The screen stayed dark. She held it close anyway, searching for a sign the meme would return, the way a person might press a bruise just to confirm it's real.

In the mirror, her face stared back.

It looked like her. It also didn't. The difference was small enough that she could almost talk herself into it - almost. The left side of her mouth sat a fraction higher. Her eyes carried a sharper, unfamiliar steadiness. When she tried to form her usual expression, the muscles resisted, like her face had been taught a new default.

Her throat worked around a sound she wouldn't let out. She turned away from the mirror and moved fast, stumbling toward her front door with the dead phone in her hand.

In the living room, the TV screen glowed faintly from the dark, though she hadn't turned it on. The black glass caught a smear of light like an afterimage, and in it, for a brief, sickening second, the livestream close-up flickered.

Mara didn't look again.

She fumbled with her keys, metal clinking against the lock. The hallway outside was cold and quiet, the kind of quiet that made her feel like she'd stepped into someone else's apartment. Her hands shook so badly she missed the key twice.

Behind her, the mirror's reflection shifted - just a twitch, just enough to suggest the meme had found a new place to play when the phone went dark.

Mara got the door open and shoved herself into the corridor, breathing hard. The world smelled like old carpet and someone's laundry detergent. Real. Physical. Safe enough for one step.

She didn't dare glance back until the elevator doors opened with a tired ding.

In the dark reflection of the elevator's metal panel, her face caught under the overhead light - still hers, still changing. A fraction different, like it had already decided what version of her would fit.

The doors began to close.

Mara lifted her hand and watched her fingers rise in the reflection, slower than her own will for one last beat, and then the elevator swallowed her image into darkness as she descended, carrying the dead phone like proof of a prank that wasn't done ruining her yet.



Mirror Proof and Self-Doubt

The elevator's last shudder died somewhere behind her, and the hallway swallowed the sound of her footsteps the way water swallows light. Mara stood in front of her apartment door with the dead phone clutched in her palm, its glass cool and slick against her skin, and tried to breathe like the air hadn't turned thick and metallic on the way down. Her reflection in the dark metal of the building's latch looked wrong - not wrong enough to point at, just wrong enough to make her stomach clench with every blink.

She fished her keys out with fingers that felt fractionally slower than they should have been. In the lock, the tumblers clicked too cleanly, like the door had never been touched. When she turned the knob, the apartment smelled faintly of detergent and old coffee grounds, familiar and safe. That safety lasted until she caught her face in the entry mirror - until she saw her own eyes sit slightly differently in her face, as if someone had nudged the seating of them while she wasn't looking.

Mara yanked the bathroom light on hard enough to make the bulb buzz. The mirror above the sink flared white. Her skin looked normal in the harsh glare, but the longer she stared, the more her features tried to settle into two versions of themselves: one that matched the memory of last night, and one that matched the shape in the glass. She couldn't hold both at once. Each time she focused on the mirror, the remembered face slid away like a finger slipping off wet glass.

"I'm not doing this," she said, voice too loud in the small room. The words sounded like they belonged to someone else.

She set her phone on the counter anyway, dead screen angled toward the mirror. The screen stayed dark, but she could feel the device in the air around it, like a pressure change before a storm. Her laptop sat open on the kitchen table where she'd left it - she'd told herself she would check later, after she stopped shaking - but she didn't want later. Later was how the meme kept winning.

Mara ripped open the bathroom cabinet for the older camera she used for documenting her plant cuttings. The lens was scuffed. The strap smelled faintly of sweat and plastic. She brought it to the mirror, palms damp, and clicked the shutter. The camera made a sharp little sound that should've anchored her in reality.

In the screen, her face appeared - hers, in pixels - but the angle was wrong. The jawline looked a hair narrower, the cheekbone a shade more pronounced. She leaned in, trying to find the distortion, the lens trick. The glass didn't distort. The mirror didn't flicker. The image simply sat there like it had always been true.

"No," Mara whispered. She tapped the camera's playback and watched the captured frame again. Her eyes looked the same shade of brown they always were, but their spacing felt altered, a subtle shift that made her feel like she was looking at a cousin she'd never met.

She grabbed a photo strip from the drawer by the sink - four prints stacked in a strip sleeve. Ethan had taken them months ago when they'd been drunk on cheap takeout and laughing too hard to remember to be careful. Mara had kept them because she liked how her face looked uncomplicated there, soft at the edges. The strip smelled faintly of chemical paper and her own perfume from that night, like time had left residue.

She held the prints up beside the mirror. The bathroom light turned the photo glossy, and the surface of the prints caught her reflection in tiny, broken fragments. Her fingers trembled as she lined the strip's edge with the mirror's vertical line.

The version in the photos looked like her - right nose, right mouth, right scar near her chin from when she'd fallen off a bike at thirteen. The version in the mirror didn't have the same scar shape. The faint pale mark was still there, but the curve at the end had softened, as if it had healed wrong, like skin trying to remember a different injury.

Mara stared until her eyes burned. She blinked hard and rubbed the corner of her brow with the heel of her hand, wiping away sweat that wasn't there a second ago.

Her phone buzzed.

Not with sound - no ringtone, no notification. The vibration traveled through the counter like a small animal under the surface of the laminate. Mara froze with her hand half-raised, the dead phone sitting there as if it had never been lifeless. The counter felt warmer where the device touched it.

She snatched the phone up and held it close to the mirror, thumb hovering over the black screen. The glass stayed dark for one breath, then the screen flared with a pale, grainy image. Not the livestream this time, not the familiar jitter of Ethan's link, but a still frame that made her stomach drop: her own bathroom mirror, taken from a slightly different angle, her face caught mid-expression as if she'd been caught reacting.

On the screen, a timestamp glowed in the corner. It wasn't from last night. It wasn't from tonight. It was from three hours from now.

Mara's throat tightened. She looked at the clock on the wall above the toilet. Its hands ticked forward with steady, stupid confidence.

The timestamp on her phone sat there, unbothered.

"What the hell is this?" she demanded, and the bathroom answered with only the hum of the light and her own breathing.

She backed away from the mirror without meaning to, the photo strip still clutched in her fingers. The dead weight of the phone felt heavier, like it had filled with something solid. She tried to swipe the screen off, to shut it down like she'd shut down the livestream. The gesture didn't register. The display held, bright and stubborn, showing her face with the same wrong scar curve, the same subtle spacing of eyes.

A memory surged - Ethan's text, the way he'd typed too fast, the link that had looked like a harmless joke. Her mind insisted she'd closed everything. She remembered standing in front of her mirror and pressing her palms flat against the glass, telling herself she'd stopped it. She remembered the elevator doors beginning to close.

And yet the evidence in her hand disagreed: the photo strip, the timestamp, the mirror.

Mara swallowed. She forced herself to focus on something small and measurable. The bathroom had a scale on the floor. She knelt and dragged it forward with a scrape that made her teeth clench. The rubber pads squeaked. Cold tile bit into her knees.

She turned on the scale. Numbers flickered, then steadied: 128.6.

She waited for the number to jump, to correct itself. It didn't. It just sat there as if it had always been that. Mara exhaled sharply, relief arriving too quickly, suspiciously so. She stepped off and on again, watching the readout.

128.6 again.

"It's not perception," she said, voice low. "It's not... it's not in my head."

The words tasted like a dare.

She stood and grabbed the camera again, pointing it at her face like a weapon. The lens reflected in the mirror, a small circle of black. She took another photo,

then another, changing angles, moving the camera a few inches to the left, then to the right. The shutter clicks filled the room, bright and mechanical, each one a promise that she could catch the meme in the act.

The camera screen displayed her face each time. Each time, the details shifted in ways that didn't line up with any normal variation of lighting or distance. Her mouth looked set differently. The right side of her face in the mirror seemed slightly higher, as if someone had tightened a string behind her cheek.

Mara's heart thudded. She tried to steady her hands by pressing her fingers against the counter's edge. The laminate was cold. Her fingertips stayed cold for a moment, then warmed quickly, as if the surface had absorbed heat from her skin and refused to let it go.

A thought came, sharp enough to cut through the panic. If the meme could rewrite her, maybe it could also be pinned down with timing.

She grabbed the photo strip again and held it up, aligning the scar with the mirror's light line. Then she looked at the mirror's version and tried to imagine her face three hours from now. The timestamp on her phone sat like a threat behind her eyes.

"No," she said again, but this time it sounded less like denial and more like fear with teeth.

Her phone buzzed once more, gentle this time, like a warning tap. Mara's gaze snapped to the screen. The still image had changed. The bathroom mirror view was the same, but her face in it looked different - subtle, yes, but different in a way that made her scalp prickle.

The scar curve looked tighter, more defined. Her jawline looked more angular, less rounded. Her eyes - her eyes looked like they were staring from a slightly different depth.

Mara stared until her vision swam. Her mind tried to supply the missing hours, tried to fill the gap with what it thought she should see. But every time she reached for a memory of her face being like that, her head offered only confusion, like trying to remember a dream while awake.

She heard herself laugh once, a small broken sound. "That's not me."

The bathroom door clicked softly behind her.

Mara turned so fast the camera strap cut into her wrist. Her apartment hallway was empty. No footsteps lingered. No shadow leaned in. The sound had come from inside her own house - inside the space between the bathroom and the living room - but the hallway remained empty as a held breath.

Her pulse hammered. She looked back at the mirror. The reflection looked back, calm and unhurried.

Mara's phone buzzed again, and this time the screen brightened into a new image: her in the bathroom, phone in her hand, camera pointed at her face. The timestamp in the corner read three hours from now, still, but the expression on her face was wrong.

Not wrong like a stranger. Wrong like her face had decided what emotion she was supposed to wear.

She recognized the angle. She recognized the position of the camera. She recognized the photo strip in her left hand - recognized it so clearly her stomach lurched. Ethan had taken those strips. She remembered the way the machine had spit them out. She remembered laughing, her cheeks sore, her hair falling into her eyes.

But in the image on her phone, the photo strip looked different. The sleeve's edges were cleaner, the paper less curled. And the face in the mirror - her face - looked even more aligned with the altered scar curve.

Mara's hands went numb around the camera. She stared at the phone's image and then at the mirror's image until the two became too close to tell apart. Her mind tried to correct itself, tried to say that the phone was lying, that she could still stop it by refusing to look, by turning away, by throwing the phone into the sink and smashing the screen - The urge was immediate and physical, like an itch she couldn't scratch. She snatched the phone up with both hands, turning it so the screen faced the tile. The glass reflected her face back at her, and she flinched at the sight of herself doing it.

"No," she said, and this time it wasn't for the meme. It was for the part of her that wanted to bargain.

She set the phone down carefully, screen still on, and grabbed her laptop from the kitchen. The hallway felt colder than it should've, air crawling along her arms. The laptop's fan kicked in with a high whine. The browser was open to the link Ethan had sent - she'd left it, still thinking she could deal with it later.

The page loaded without input, without a click. The cursor blinked where her last action should've been, and the link sat there like a wound.

Mara's stomach turned. She hadn't imagined the livestream persisting. It had followed her. It had waited.

She didn't click anything. She didn't dare. Instead she pulled up the photo folder she'd saved earlier, the images from her first night of trying to prove she wasn't crazy. Timestamped files sat in a grid, each one a tiny rectangle of evidence she'd collected while her reflection still felt like hers.

The first set of photos showed her face as she remembered it. The later ones - tonight, earlier - showed the shifts.

Mara scrolled faster than she meant to, thumb smearing across the trackpad. Her eyes snagged on a file that shouldn't have existed. The filename included today's date, but the time stamp was from after the elevator ride.

After she'd left.

She clicked it.

On the screen, her bathroom mirror filled the frame. Her face appeared in it, and this time the scar curve didn't match the one she was seeing now. Her jawline in the image looked more angular than the jawline in the mirror, like the photo had captured her at a stage she hadn't reached yet.

The worst part wasn't the change. The worst part was the expression.

In the image, her face looked like it belonged to her, but her eyes held a steadiness she didn't feel. She looked - how did her brain even phrase it - resolved. Like she'd already decided something.

Mara's breath caught. She turned her head toward the bathroom doorway as if expecting to see herself walk out. The room behind her was silent. Only the bathroom light continued its buzz, constant and indifferent.

She looked back at the laptop. Her fingers hovered over the file timestamped after she'd left. If she deleted it, she might lose the evidence. If she kept it, she'd have to accept a timeline that implied she'd already changed beyond what she remembered.

Her internal voice split into two versions. One screamed that the only thing she could control was proof. The other whispered that proof might be the trap.

The phone on the bathroom counter buzzed again, like it could hear her thoughts.

Mara closed the laptop halfway, then opened it again with a jerky movement, forcing herself to keep looking. She needed something she could trust, something that wouldn't drift with memory. She grabbed a strip of photo paper from the drawer - blank, unused - and shoved it into the small printer she'd never thrown out because it seemed quaint.

The device whirred. Warm plastic smell rose. The printer's little motor sounded like a heartbeat trying to impersonate a machine.

Mara turned the printer toward the mirror, aligning it the way she'd aligned the camera. Her hands shook hard enough to blur the printer's edge in the reflection. She took a new photo on the camera, then held the camera display steady while the printer fed the paper.

The printer spat out a fresh strip. The paper slid out with a soft, sticky sound, like tape peeling. Mara pulled the strip free and held it beside the mirror.

The photo showed her face. Not the face from the older strip. Not the face from tonight's first photos. It matched the altered scar curve she'd seen on the phone's still image - tighter, more defined - and her eyes looked set farther apart, the spacing so slight it almost passed as normal until she stared too long.

Mara's throat went dry. She hadn't noticed this alteration in the mirror. She had been collecting evidence with frantic focus, trying to catch the meme in the act, and somehow her own reflection had changed in a way her attention had slid right past.

Her mind tried to argue. It offered up the simple excuse: lighting. Angle. The camera distortion. Anything but the meme rewriting her while she looked directly at herself.

Mara pressed the fresh strip to the counter with one palm. The paper was warm from the printer. Her skin was cold. In the mirror, her face stared back with that wrong scar curve like it had always belonged there.

The bathroom felt smaller than it had a few minutes ago, as if the walls were creeping inward. The hum of the light sounded louder, the buzz turning into an almost conversational frequency.

Mara picked up her phone again and stared at the timestamp on the screen. It still read three hours from now.

Then the still image inside it refreshed, not waiting for her to blink.

In the new photo, her left hand was raised higher than it was right now, fingers spread. Her mouth was open mid-breath, as if she'd just noticed something and couldn't help reacting. And in that image, her face wore an expression Mara couldn't find on herself in the mirror - something closer to grief than fear, something she didn't remember feeling.

She held the phone so tightly the edges bit into her skin. "Which one of me is real?" she asked the bathroom, the mirror, the dead screen that refused to stay dead.

The mirror didn't answer. It only reflected her back, and the longer she stared, the more the line between the two versions of her face seemed to thin - until she couldn't tell which one she was proving.

Mara swallowed and forced herself to do the only thing that felt like control: she raised the camera again, aimed it at her face, and took one more picture, hands steadying as if she'd practiced the motion.

The shutter click sounded like a lock turning.

On the phone's screen, the timestamp flickered once - just once - and then held. The still image shifted again.

This time, the scar on her chin in the phone looked different from the scar in the mirror.

And Mara realized, with a cold clarity that made her stomach drop, that the meme wasn't just changing her appearance.

It was changing what she noticed about her own change.



The Clinic That Won't Treat

The fluorescent lights over Hawthorne Urgent Care made everything look the same shade of sick. Mara stood in the waiting room with her phone dead in her palm, the screen glass cool even through her skin, and tried not to stare at the reflection in the dark window behind the reception desk. The glass held her face like a bruise - still hers, but not quite aligned with how her mind insisted it should be.

"I'm not here for a panic attack," she said, and her voice came out too sharp for the carpeted hush. A nurse at the counter didn't look up from the keyboard. The badge on her chest swung once when she typed, then settled again. "I have photo evidence."

"Mm." The nurse's pen clicked. "So do a lot of people. What symptoms are you having?"

Mara swallowed. Her throat felt dry, as if she'd been breathing dust. "Physical changes. Facial. They're - " She forced herself to breathe through her nose, smelling coffee that had gone stale and something chemical underneath, like bleach in an old mop bucket. "They accelerate when I look at mirrors."

The nurse finally lifted her eyes. Her expression was practiced neutrality, the kind that made Mara feel like she was speaking through a wall. "That happens. Stress can - "

"It's not stress." The dead weight of her phone pulled at her hand. She opened her camera roll on her own phone anyway, thumb hovering over the folder Ethan

had helped her organize the night she realized the livestream wouldn't shut off. The timestamped image she'd circled earlier sat there like a photograph that belonged to a stranger. Her face in it didn't match the way she felt inside her skin.

The nurse glanced once, then turned her attention back to Mara's posture, her blinking, her hands. "You're very upset. We can absolutely see you for anxiety, and if there's anything else, we'll address it."

Mara heard Ethan's voice in her head from days ago - Don't make it worse by arguing with it, just document it, just see what it does. The advice sounded sane until she tried to apply it, until the waiting room air thickened and her reflection in the window seemed to lag behind her movements by half a second, like the glass was deciding what version of her to show.

"I'm not anxious," Mara said, and hated how thin it sounded. She pushed the phone forward on the counter. "Please. If you log it wrong, if you don't - "

"We don't do pattern logging." The nurse's smile was small and tight. "We can't confirm anything like that."

Behind Mara, a man in a flannel shirt coughed so hard his whole chest jerked. A woman with a scarf held a tissue to her nose and stared at the TV mounted on the wall, the volume low and the captions unreadable from where Mara stood. The room had the steady, muffled sound of people waiting to be told their fear was ordinary.

Mara wanted confirmation. Not a guess, not a dismissal. Something with a name that could be written on a form. Something that would turn her face from a moving target into a diagnosis she could fight. She needed the clinic to say, yes, this is a thing that happens, yes, it has a cause, yes, there's treatment.

She didn't say treatment out loud. The word felt too close to desperation.

"Please," she said again, and this time she offered the one thing she'd brought besides the dead phone - printed strips from her older camera, the ones she'd taken before the meme started rewriting what her reflection meant. The glossy paper smelled faintly of toner when she laid it on the counter. The nurse's gaze flicked over it, then slid away as if the images were embarrassing.

"These are... photos," the nurse said. "Of what looks like - " Her pen hovered. "Skin changes?"

"It's not just skin," Mara snapped, then forced her jaw to unclench. The waiting room seemed to breathe in with her anger. "My face. My - shape. My eyes. It's like my expression is shifting without me choosing it. I can feel it when I'm near mirrors."

The nurse's pen resumed tapping. "We can check your vitals. If you're having a reaction, we'll look for infection, allergic response, neurological signs - "

Mara's fingers curled around the edge of the counter. The laminate was cool and slightly tacky. "But it doesn't behave like that. It doesn't show up like a rash. It happens when I look. It's like - " She almost said the word meme, but the nurse would hear it as a joke, as a social media thing Mara had gotten herself into. "It's like exposure."

The nurse's expression tightened again, and Mara realized with a sick lurch that the nurse wasn't just dismissing her. She was already building a story in her head, one that made Mara's fear belong to a category that could be filed away without changing anything about the clinic.

"Exposure to what?" a voice asked from the side.

Mara turned. A man in a white coat had appeared near the hallway that led to exam rooms. He looked tired around the eyes, hair flattened by hats or long shifts, but his posture held authority. His ID badge read PHYSICIAN ASSISTANT, and his gaze landed on Mara's hands first, then the phone, then the papers.

Mara clung to the thin hope in her chest. "Sir - " She stopped herself. She didn't know his name. "Exposure to something that alters appearance. I watched a livestream. I got a link from Ethan. And now - "

The physician assistant's jaw flexed. "You're saying it's contagious."

"It's exposure," Mara insisted. "I don't know if contagious is the right word. I don't know what it is. But other people - " She wanted to ask if anyone else had come in, if anyone else had said the same thing. She needed someone to confirm she wasn't the only one whose face felt like it was moving to a rhythm she couldn't hear.

The physician assistant glanced toward the nurse. The nurse's pen stopped. For a beat, the only sound was the flannel man's cough and the low murmur of the TV.

"We can examine you," the physician assistant said carefully. "We can't treat something we can't identify. And if there's a contagion concern, we have protocols."

Mara's mouth went dry again. Protocols sounded like doors that wouldn't open. "You can log it and rule out other causes. You can document the pattern."

"We don't log patterns," the physician assistant repeated, softer this time, as if he was trying to keep her from breaking. "We document findings. If you have a symptom, tell us what it is."

Mara stared at him, the fluorescent lights making his skin look waxy. Her mind kept snagging on the detail she'd noticed in her reflections earlier, the way her gaze sometimes didn't line up with her own. She reached for the memory like it was a railing and found it slipping.

"I can't keep track," she admitted, and the confession tasted like metal. "It's changing too fast. I'll look away and when I look back - "

"Changes in perception can happen with stress, migraine, medication side effects..." The nurse spoke again, her tone gentler, the way people got when they thought they were correcting a misunderstanding. "Have you taken anything? Any new supplements?"

Mara shook her head. "No. Nothing."

The physician assistant moved closer to the counter. "Can you describe what you're seeing right now?"

Right now. Mara forced herself to glance at the window behind the desk. Her reflection stared back with the same eyes she'd always had, except the pupils looked slightly off-center, as if her face had rotated a fraction too far without her permission. The skin around her mouth looked tighter. Her cheeks held a tension she hadn't felt a moment ago.

She lifted her hand slowly, like she was demonstrating a symptom to a skeptical doctor. In the glass, her fingers rose a fraction behind, then snapped into alignment a heartbeat later. Mara's stomach rolled. She could feel the delay in her bones, the way you feel a word on the tip of your tongue before you remember how it's spelled.

"It's doing it," she whispered.

The nurse's gaze followed hers to the window, and her expression changed - just for a second. Not fear. Not disgust. Something like recognition, as if Mara had said a word the clinic had heard too many times.

"Okay," the physician assistant said, voice tightening. He didn't look at Mara's reflection again. He looked at Mara. "We'll get you into an exam room."

Relief hit like a wave, immediate and dangerous, and Mara almost believed she'd won.

"Sign in," the nurse said briskly, and slid a clipboard toward her. The paper was already filled with other names, other reasons for being here. Mara took the pen. It felt heavier than it should have, the ink thick, the paper rough under her thumb.

As she wrote her name, the letters wobbled. She stopped, stared at the line she'd just made, then tried again. The ink pooled slightly, as if it didn't want to dry. Her handwriting looked like it belonged to someone who'd practiced copying hers.

"Ma'am?" the nurse prompted.

Mara forced the pen down harder. The sound of it scratching on paper was too loud in the quiet room.

A minute later she was escorted toward the hallway. The physician assistant walked ahead, keys jangling at his belt. His shoes squeaked faintly on the linoleum. Mara followed, her phone cold in her hand, her printed photos pressed against her ribs like a shield.

The exam room door swung shut with a soft click that made Mara flinch. The air inside was cooler, smelling of alcohol wipes and latex. A blood pressure cuff hung on the wall like a sleeping animal. A paper gown lay folded on the chair.

"Vitals first," the physician assistant said. He pulled a stethoscope from around his neck. The metal smelled faintly of old breath.

Mara sat. The chair was vinyl, sticky where other people had sweated. When she leaned forward, her reflection in the small wall mirror above the sink flickered with that same delay, and Mara's face in it looked just slightly more wrong. Her mouth in the mirror held a smile she wasn't making.

"I didn't consent to - " she started, but her voice caught. The physician assistant was already wrapping the cuff around her upper arm. The rubber pressed into

her skin with a firm, clinical certainty that made the rest of her body feel suddenly unreal.

"Don't move," he said.

Mara watched the digital display as it inflated. The number climbed. The room filled with the rhythmic pump sound. Her pulse thudded under the cuff, loud in her ears.

When it reached a number that should have hurt, it didn't. The pain never arrived. Instead, a numb warmth spread through her arm, and with it came a strange clarity - her mind felt too clean, like a page scrubbed with chemicals.

"What did you take?" the physician assistant asked again, and the question sounded far away.

Mara tried to answer, but the words tangled. Her attention drifted to the mirror. Her reflection blinked a moment too late. Her lashes moved like they were remembering how to work.

"I didn't take anything," she said, but her voice sounded different. Not louder. Not softer. Just... slightly rearranged, like the sound had been filtered through a face that wasn't fully hers.

The physician assistant's eyebrows drew together. He glanced at the monitor, then at Mara. "Okay. I'm going to check your skin."

He pulled on gloves. The latex made a whispering sound against his wrists. He lifted Mara's chin with two fingers, turning her head gently. Up close, the physician assistant's breath smelled like gum and coffee.

"Have you noticed any swelling? Any numbness? Any difficulty speaking?"

Mara opened her mouth to answer and froze. Her tongue felt normal, her teeth felt normal, but the mirror above the sink showed her mouth opening in a way

her body wasn't doing. In the glass, her lips formed a word without sound. The shape was familiar, like she'd seen it in the livestream.

She jerked her head back. The motion made her chair squeal against the floor.

"What?" the physician assistant demanded, but his tone wasn't angry. It was alert.

Mara swallowed hard. "It's copying me."

The physician assistant stared for a long beat. Then he reached for his phone, tapping quickly. The screen lit his face from below, making his eyes look hollow.

Mara's chest tightened. "Who are you calling?"

"Contagion review," he said, and the words landed like a lock turning. He didn't look at her when he spoke. "Stay here."

The room felt smaller immediately, the air turning thick. Mara sat back, gloved hands still on her face where he'd adjusted her chin, and forced herself to breathe. Her fingers dug into the vinyl seat.

She watched the door seam. Watched the light under it. Listened to the faint hallway noise - shoes, voices, the click of a key turning somewhere out of sight.

Then her reflection changed again.

Not slowly. Not like before. It tightened in a way that made Mara's stomach lurch, as if her face were pulling itself toward a shape she'd already seen in that future photo from her dead phone. The corners of her mouth rose by degrees she hadn't ordered. The skin around her eyes smoothed into a look that felt like someone else had practiced it.

Mara pressed her palms against her cheeks. The mirror showed her doing it. But the timing was wrong - her reflection's hands met her face an instant after her own, like the meme was watching her from the other side of glass.

She heard the physician assistant return. Keys jangled. He opened the door with a controlled firmness that didn't match the panic Mara felt rising in her throat.

"Okay," he said, and his voice had changed. It held a careful distance, like he'd decided not to believe her anymore. "We can't continue with treatment here."

Mara sat so still her body began to ache. "What do you mean?"

He held up his phone, thumbed across the screen, then looked at her like he was delivering a verdict. "Contagion review has locked the referral desk. We can't log this as a standard case. We can't - " He swallowed. "We can't see you beyond this point."

Mara's ears rang. "You said you'd examine me. You said you'd check findings."

"We did." He glanced at the cuff on her arm, at the monitor. "Your vitals are stable. The symptoms you describe don't map cleanly. That's what they told me."

Mara almost laughed, the sound trapped behind her teeth. Stable. As if stable could mean safe. As if the meme needed her blood pressure to cooperate.

"What about my photos?" she demanded. She thrust the printed strips toward him. "Look at them. Look at the progression."

The physician assistant didn't take them. His gaze slid over the paper without focusing, like his eyes had been trained not to linger. "We can't accept diagnostic evidence from social media exposures."

Mara's throat tightened until words hurt. "It's not social media. It's - " She stopped, because if she named it, she could feel the waiting room pulling it into the category they wanted: anxious, delusional, contagious in a way they could shut down.

The physician assistant reached under the counter and pulled out a slip of paper. The paper was thick. Official. He held it between two fingers like it might

contaminate him anyway.

"A referral," he said. "To a review office. Not treatment - review. It's already closed for contagion review."

Mara stared at the slip. Her handwriting, her name, sat at the top of it - recorded, filed, already turned into something bureaucratic. She could smell the ink on it, sharp and fresh, while her phone in her palm stayed dead and cold.

Her pulse hammered once, hard enough to make her vision blur.

"So what am I supposed to do with it?" she asked, and her voice trembled despite her effort to keep it steady.

The physician assistant's mouth tightened. "You can leave. They'll call if they need more information."

Leave. The word scraped her nerves raw. She could already feel the waiting room behind her, the fluorescent hum, the chairs, the people with their ordinary illnesses. She could already feel the locked referral desk, the closed doors that had decided her case was too messy to touch.

Mara looked down at her printed photos again. The glossy paper caught the overhead light and showed her face in strips that didn't agree with her memory. In one image, her eyes sat where they should have. In the next, the shape of her mouth had shifted. In the next - she could feel the future photo's presence like a weight in her pocket even though it was still on the dead phone, still trapped in glass.

The meme didn't need her permission. It didn't need a diagnosis. It only needed exposure.

Mara stood too fast. The chair squealed again. The physician assistant moved back a step, gloved hands hovering as if distance could protect him.

"Wait," Mara said, and her hand tightened around the dead phone. "If the office is closed, where do I - "

The physician assistant held up a hand. "The referral office is closed. For contagion review."

The repetition of it made Mara's skin crawl. Contagion review. Like the clinic had decided her problem was something that could spread just by proximity, just by conversation.

Mara's mouth opened. No words came out. She felt her face in the mirror above the sink - felt it shifting, felt the delay between her movement and its imitation. The room smelled like alcohol and latex and something faintly sweet, like bruised fruit left too long in a drawer.

She backed out of the exam room anyway, because the doors in her life had started closing before she could argue.

In the hallway, the nurse stood by the counter, her eyes fixed on a clipboard. When Mara passed, the nurse's gaze flicked to the slip in Mara's hand, then away, like she'd already marked Mara's file as handled.

The waiting room sound rose as Mara stepped back into it - the cough, the TV captions, the soft shuffle of shoes. Fluorescent light buzzed across the carpet and made the whole place look like a hospital set built for someone else's story.

Mara walked to the locked referral desk at the far wall. The window in it was dark, blinds drawn. A sign on the glass read CLOSED in block letters, the ink too bold for something so final.

She pressed her palm to the glass. It was cold enough to bite. Her reflection in it looked almost normal for a second, almost aligned. Then, as if responding to the contact, her smile in the glass deepened without her permission.

Behind her, the waiting room door opened and shut with a soft thud, letting in a gust of outside air that smelled like hot pavement and rain. Footsteps echoed down the hall, heading toward the counter.

Mara pulled her hand away from the glass and held the referral slip tighter, the paper bending slightly under her grip. The office was closed. The clinic wouldn't log the pattern. The meme didn't care about their protocols.

All she had left was proof - photos, timestamps, a dead phone that still felt warm in her palm even though the screen stayed dark - and a referral slip that led to a door she couldn't open.

When she turned, her reflection in the waiting room window looked back at her with a face that didn't quite match the one she felt inside her skull, like it was practicing for the moment the doors shut entirely.



Who Uploaded the Meme First

The waiting room window held her face like a dare, a pale rectangle of light and glass between her and the hallway that wouldn't open for her. Mara stood with the referral slip folded into her palm until the paper softened, her fingers aching from holding it too tight. Behind her, someone's TV murmured through static; every sound felt muffled, as if the clinic had wrapped the world in gauze. The door with the contagion sign had stayed shut when the physician assistant - kind, then not - had taken her photos and her dead phone and said, "We can't verify this."

Verify. Like the proof in her hands was a rumor.

She could still feel the dead phone's warmth from earlier, the way it hadn't cooled when it should have. It sat heavy in her bag now, a brick that refused to become harmless. The last thing she'd seen in the waiting room window was her reflection practicing a different expression, lips slightly parted like it had learned a new way to look surprised. When she turned away, her stomach tightened with the sense that the glass had already recorded the motion and stored it somewhere.

Ethan's message burned in her notifications: *Late-night place on Cherry. Wi-Fi that doesn't ask questions.* He'd sounded tired when he sent it, like he'd been awake long enough to forget which hours belonged to him. Mara didn't have the energy to be grateful. She only had the question, sharp as a pin behind her teeth: who uploaded it first?

If she could find the original uploader, she could stop chasing her own altered face like it was the only lead left. The clinic had given her a referral and a shrug; she needed a route that didn't end behind a closed door. She needed to know why the meme targeted bodies, why it let the world watch and then - slowly, patiently - edited the watcher.

The late-night internet café on Cherry Street smelled like burnt coffee and warm plastic. It was quieter than it looked from the street, a thin hush punctuated by the click of keyboards and the occasional hiss of a soda being opened. Mara slid into the borrowed booth at the back, her shoulders tight under her jacket, and set her laptop on the scratched table. The fan above her spun weakly, pushing air that tasted faintly of dust and sugar.

Her camera sat beside the laptop, older than she liked to admit. She'd brought it because the mirror lied in small ways, because reflections could smudge memory, because proof had to start somewhere real. Tonight she needed timestamps, upload trails, anything that could pin the meme down to a person and a moment.

The meme link was still open in the browser history, even though she'd closed the page earlier at the clinic. The dead phone had gone dark again, yet the link on her laptop carried the same thumbnail - grainy, cropped, a face that wasn't quite hers. Mara hovered her cursor over the video source, feeling heat rise in her cheeks from the effort of making herself look at something that had already changed her.

"Don't do it," she muttered, not sure whether she was talking to herself or the screen. Her voice sounded too loud in the booth.

A hiss from the audio speakers answered her, low and distant, as if the café itself was breathing.

She pulled up the page source. HTML lines cascaded down like a cold waterfall. Her hands shook just enough to make the text blur at the edges, but she could

still recognize the structure: embedded scripts, a video player hosted elsewhere, a short link that looked like it had been cleaned and rewrapped too many times. Mara leaned closer until the screen's glow warmed her eyes.

"Come on," she whispered. "If you're real, then show me where you started."

The first obstacle wasn't technical. It was the time.

Every trail she followed split, then reassembled wrong. One repost claimed the meme began two days ago. Another archived version insisted it was posted a week earlier. A third link - buried in some comment chain - showed an upload time that landed in the middle of a date range that didn't exist on the platform. Mara found the discrepancy by accident, then couldn't stop staring at it, the way her brain kept trying to reconcile the impossible with something familiar.

At the bottom of one page, a thumbnail loaded late, stuttering like a video buffering through fog. Mara's stomach tightened when it finally resolved. The face in the thumbnail looked... almost right, but the proportions were off in a way that made her eyes itch. Her cheek was slightly different. The shadow under her jaw sat wrong. It was a version of her that had never been allowed to become her.

She jerked her gaze away and glanced at her phone - dead, black, silent. The weight of it in her bag made her feel like she was carrying a second heartbeat.

Her second obstacle was the café itself. The booth's Wi-Fi signal was unstable. The page source would load, then freeze. The cursor would blink, then pause as if someone else had taken hold of the mouse. Once, the screen flickered and the video player returned to the meme thumbnail without her clicking anything. The audio didn't start, but the frame shifted - one step closer to that wrong-cheek expression.

Mara sat back hard enough that the vinyl seat squeaked. Her skin went cold under her jacket. She stared at the laptop like it might blink first.

"You're doing this," she said, and the words sounded foolish, like accusing a storm. Still, she meant it.

Across the café, someone laughed at a screen and kept typing, oblivious. No one else seemed to notice the way the air in the booth felt thick, like the glow from the laptop had turned into something you could almost touch.

Mara tried again. She opened a different tab and searched for the meme's original hash - a string of characters she'd once seen on a forum that traced content across mirrors. The search results came back fast, too fast, as if the internet had been waiting to show her exactly what she needed and nothing beyond it.

There it was: an account name that didn't look like a person. Numbers layered over letters, then deleted, then reappeared with a different capitalization. A burner profile. The kind of thing that existed only to pass things along and vanish before anyone could grab them.

Her throat went tight. "Okay," she breathed. "Fine. You're reachable."

The lead came concrete the moment she clicked.

A server log fragment sat in a cached paste on a forum - small, partial, like someone had torn a page from a book and slid it into the wrong pocket. Mara recognized the format: request headers, a timestamp, a referer field. In the referer, a short link she'd seen earlier in the HTML. In the timestamp, a moment that matched the earliest upload time she'd been chasing, except it didn't match any calendar she knew. It was off by minutes that shouldn't matter - and yet made her skin crawl.

The fragment ended mid-line, as if the log had been cut before it could reveal the rest. But it did something else: it included a user agent string. Not generic. Not masked.

It named a device.

Mara's eyes flicked to her dead phone in her bag, and she hated the thought that arrived before she could stop it. She didn't want the connection because it was too close to coincidence. She didn't want it because it implied the meme wasn't just watching through screens. It was watching through the path her own devices took.

She swallowed and pulled up the burner profile. The page loaded with a clean, blank header, as if it had been scrubbed for her benefit. No profile picture. No bio. Just one post, pinned at the top.

A video file name sat under it like a label on a jar.

Mara's hands hovered over the trackpad. Her reflection in the darkened portion of the laptop screen didn't match her posture anymore. She could feel her own face moving in her skull, trying to prepare a reaction before her muscles agreed. The air tasted metallic, like pennies held too long on the tongue.

Her phone buzzed once in her bag.

It wasn't a notification sound. It was a vibration - short, frantic, like the dead phone had remembered how to move. Mara jerked the bag open and pulled it out. The screen stayed dark, but the edges of the device glowed faintly, a bruised light crawling just under the glass.

Her reflection in the laptop screen flared brighter for a second, and the face in it looked closer to the wrong-cheek thumbnail than to Mara's own memory. Her heart hammered so hard it felt like it could shake her ribs loose.

"What do you want?" she asked the air.

The burner profile's pinned video started without her clicking. The player bar appeared at the bottom, loading buffer dots spinning with lazy confidence. There was no audio at first - just the image filling the screen.

A grainy recording. A timestamp in the corner. A face framed in the same crop as the meme she'd watched on Ethan's link - close enough that the viewer couldn't pretend it was generic. The lighting was harsh, the kind you got in cheap rooms where the bulbs were old and too bright. The person in the video blinked.

Mara's stomach dropped because the blink wasn't a stranger's blink. It was hers, only performed with a slight delay, like the timing had been edited.

She snapped her gaze away and grabbed her camera with shaking fingers. The lens felt cool and solid in her palm, a relief compared to the laptop's glow. She aimed it at the screen and pressed the shutter. The camera clicked - sharp, mechanical - and the sound steadied her enough to think.

"Stop," she said, louder this time. Her voice cracked on the last word.

In the booth's reflection on the laptop screen, her face widened in a way her muscles hadn't decided on. The wrong-cheek version smiled like it had been waiting for her to speak.

She forced her eyes back to the laptop and watched the video continue. The pinned post had no caption, but the video itself carried something like a response: a new overlay of text that faded in line by line, too small to read clearly at first.

Mara leaned closer until her breath fogged the screen. The text resolved. Not a warning. Not an explanation.

It was a date.

It was the same date as the server log fragment, the moment the earliest upload trail had pointed to. Only now the timestamp shifted again, scrolling forward as if the post was alive. As if it could react to her presence.

Then the video's face moved closer to the camera, filling the frame. Mara's skin prickled. She could feel the heat of the laptop glow on her cheeks, feel it trying to imprint itself. The person in the video - her, again, but not her - tilted their head.

The movement mirrored the way Mara had seen her reflection practice surprise in the clinic window. Practicing. Learning. Preparing.

Mara's fingers tightened on the camera until her knuckles hurt.

"Who uploaded it?" she demanded, and she hated that it came out sounding like pleading. "Who - "

The audio kicked in suddenly, a faint sound under the grain: a phone camera microphone picking up breathing and the soft click of someone adjusting a lens. The sound was too close. It felt like it was coming from the booth itself.

A voice spoke in the video. Not Ethan's. Not a name Mara recognized. It was low and distorted, as if the speaker knew the recording would be played on a thousand different devices with different speakers.

"First," the voice said. Then, after a pause long enough to feel deliberate, "You did."

Mara froze. The words didn't make sense, and her brain tried to scramble for a rational gap. She had never uploaded anything. She had never posted a link. The meme had come to her from Ethan, a message on a screen while she sat in her own apartment with her dead phone asleep in her pocket.

Still, her body reacted like it had heard the truth.

Her face in the laptop went slack for a fraction of a second, then tightened again into that wrong-cheek expression. The smile returned, slow and patient, like a hinge lubricated from the inside.

Mara's borrowed booth chair squeaked when she shifted, and the sound dragged the attention of the person behind the counter. A man in a flannel shirt looked over, eyebrows raised. "Everything okay?"

Mara wanted to lie. She wanted to say it was just a buffering video, just a glitch, just her nerves. But the air felt too thick with attention, and the laptop's glow made her feel exposed, like her face was already an open file.

"It's - " She swallowed. "It won't stop."

The man's eyes flicked to the screen. His expression changed in a way Mara couldn't name. He didn't look alarmed. He looked... cautious, like he recognized something he shouldn't. He stepped closer, then stopped short of the booth's edge.

"Don't watch it," he said, too quickly, as if he'd rehearsed the line. His voice was rough, like he hadn't used it much. "Just close the tab."

Mara's pulse spiked. She stared at him, and for a moment she saw something in his face that made her want to run - an awareness, a memory of the meme without admitting it.

"How do you know?" she asked.

He hesitated. The café's background noise seemed to drop, as if the sound had turned away to listen. His gaze kept sliding toward Mara's face, toward the reflection on the laptop screen, toward the space where the wrong-cheek smile lived.

"I've seen..." he began, then cut himself off. He licked his lips, eyes flicking to her camera. "You're documenting."

Mara tightened her grip. "I'm finding out who uploaded it."

The flannel-shirt man didn't answer. He reached toward the laptop, then pulled his hand back at the last second, like the screen might bite. "It doesn't like

being chased."

Mara wanted to scream at him. She wanted to demand proof, demand his connection, demand why he knew the meme's moods. Instead, she watched the video overlay finish its scrolling date and settle into a single line of text.

The line wasn't addressed to her. It was addressed to the world, like a message pinned to the top of a room.

It displayed the burner profile's username, but the username shifted as if trying on new letters. Under it, a new label appeared.

Mara watched her own name populate the field.

Not Ethan's. Not the flannel-shirt man's. Hers.

The wrong-cheek smile on the video widened, and the person in the frame blinked again - slower this time, like the meme had learned her timing from her reactions.

Mara's throat went dry. She forced the laptop back with her palm, pressing the trackpad hard enough to make the cursor jump. She clicked the browser's close button, then the tab. The screen didn't vanish. The page didn't refresh. It simply shifted, as if it had been prepared to survive every attempt.

The pinned video remained, but now the frame changed.

Her face filled the laptop, clearer than before, not grainy anymore. The lighting matched the café booth's overhead bulbs. Her eyes looked too bright. Her mouth held a line that was almost her own, but the corners sat wrong - like someone had measured her and adjusted the angles with careful hands.

Mara lifted her head slowly, terrified to confirm what her skin already felt. The booth's dark window reflected her.

For a moment, the reflection was her - her jacket, her tired eyes, the set of her shoulders from earlier in the clinic waiting room.

Then the reflection lagged.

Her reflection blinked after she did, and when it opened its eyes, the wrong-cheek expression was there again, settled like it had always belonged. The smile wasn't on Mara's face in her skull, not yet. But it was already on the glass.

The dead phone in her bag warmed faintly, a pulse through fabric that made her teeth ache.

The flannel-shirt man backed away a step, as if he'd finally decided to fear the same thing she did. "Okay," he said, barely audible. "Okay. That's - "

Mara turned her camera toward her reflection on the window. The camera's viewfinder showed her face changing in real time, the way it had earlier in the meme livestream - subtle, then suddenly undeniable. She pressed the shutter again and again until her finger cramped.

The laptop screen displayed the meme video, and the video displayed her face with a response overlay that kept refreshing, the burner profile sending another "reply" into the same loop.

Mara's question - who uploaded it first - had been answered in a way that didn't feel like information. It felt like a trap with words.

She stared at the username field on the screen until it stabilized. The server log fragment in the cached paste sat behind the video in another tab, proof of a trail that led to a burner profile that was responsive, alive to her attention.

A log fragment tied to a burner profile.

And the burner profile that posted a response video using her face.

Mara's breath came shallow. The café's air seemed to vibrate with the hum of servers she couldn't see. Her camera's shutter clicks sounded too loud, like she was knocking on a door that had been closed for a reason.

Outside the booth, the clinic doors felt far away. The referral slip in her palm felt suddenly useless, paper against something that could reach back through screens and rearrange what she thought she knew.

She leaned forward until the laptop glow warmed her cheek, and she made herself look at the video's face - at the way it smiled when she tried to stop it.

The meme wasn't just an upload anymore. It was a conversation.

And somewhere behind the burner profile, behind the partial logs and the shifting timestamps, something had learned how to answer her.



The Citywide Tagging Wave

The subway platform breathed in bursts of cold air and hot breath, a moving lung of people and noise. Mara stood under the fluorescent ribs of the station, phone clenched in her right hand, and watched her own face get used like a caption.

The burner feed had been a dead-end in the dark hours of the café, but the response video wasn't. The clip looped on her phone like a nervous tic: a grainy overlay of her - her altered face, the one she'd only seen on the dead phone's future photo - talking without sound. The mouth moved a half-second off from where it should've, like the video had learned her from memory instead of skin. QR tags flashed on the ads above the tracks, white squares crawling across glossy billboards, and every time a train roared through, the screen glare made the tags blink brighter, as if they were responding to motion.

Mara's stomach rolled. She could still feel the weight of last night's dead phone in her palm, even though it wasn't in her pocket now. She'd brought it out once more in the apartment, just to make sure she wasn't lying to herself, just to make sure the changes weren't a dream her brain had invented to punish her. The reflection had shifted again, slightly, the kind of shift you only noticed when you tried to remember yesterday's exact angle of your own cheek.

Her phone buzzed again - another alert, another link preview - while the burner video continued to stutter on her screen.

Ethan had said it like a warning and a dare: Don't look away. Don't click. Don't let it touch anything else. But the whole world around her looked like it had

already clicked.

Mara wanted one thing, sharp enough to hurt her teeth: stop the spread before it landed in the places that mattered. She didn't want to play detective anymore. She didn't want to argue with clinics or doubt her own face. She wanted to warn people - before the tag reached their feeds, before the meme threaded itself into their reflections the way it had threaded itself into hers.

She shoved her thumb toward the share icon out of pure instinct, then stopped when her screen flashed a reminder she'd never asked to see: "Link detected. Suggestions available."

Suggestions. Like it was helping.

A man in a flannel shirt leaned against the far column, scrolling with both hands as if he were killing time instead of feeding the same hunger. A woman with a scarf stood near the edge of the platform, her phone angled up toward the ad screens, QR squares pulsing across her view like a second set of eyes. When the train's wind hit, the scarf lifted and snapped back down, the fabric whispering against itself, and Mara's skin tightened the way it did when she'd seen her face get used on that video.

She tried to keep her breathing even. The station smelled like metal and wet concrete. Her tongue tasted faintly of pennies.

"Mara."

The voice came from behind her, cutting through the loudness like a finger through cloth. Ethan wasn't supposed to be here - he'd been at his job, he'd said he'd meet her after he checked the last logs, he'd said he'd keep his phone off for a few hours. But he was there now, close enough that she could see the tiny cracks in the screen protector on his own device.

His eyes flicked to her phone, to the burner feed, to the distorted version of her face moving without sound.

"You're still watching it," he said.

"I found the response video." Her voice came out too fast. "It's showing me - showing my face. It's not just a livestream. It's answering."

Ethan's mouth tightened. "It's doing more than answering. It's... routing."

"Routing," Mara repeated, and the word tasted wrong, like it belonged to computers, not to her cheeks and eyes.

Ethan held up his phone. The lock screen displayed a notification bar filled with messages he hadn't composed. His thumb hovered, trembling slightly. "I tried to block the link. I tried to delete it. It keeps coming back like it's already in the system."

The station lights flickered as another train approached. The sound rose into a roar, and for a moment Mara couldn't hear her own thoughts.

Then her phone buzzed again - harder, like a heartbeat trying to force its way out of her hand.

A new message draft opened by itself.

To: Tessa Nolan Preview: "Did you see this? It's... it's real, I swear - "

Mara stared until her eyes watered. Her fingers went numb around the edges of the phone. She hadn't typed anything. She hadn't touched her contacts.

Ethan saw her face change - saw it happen in front of him, or maybe he was just good at noticing panic. "Mara," he said quietly. "It's doing it to you too."

Her throat felt too narrow. "No. I didn't - " The words fell apart. She looked at the message field. Cursor blinking. Ready to send.

The meme wasn't just altering appearances. It was reaching outward through her network like a hand pushing a door open.

Mara slapped her thumb against "Cancel," then hit the back button hard enough to make her knuckle sting. The draft disappeared, but the notification stayed, the preview still there like a stain.

Another buzz. Another draft.

To: Ethan Preview: "Watch - please, I think it's - "

"No," Mara whispered, and it came out like a plea and an accusation. She turned her phone screen away from Ethan, as if covering it could hide it from whatever was inside it.

Ethan grabbed her wrist, firm. "Don't - don't hit anything else. If you keep tapping, it might interpret it as consent."

"Consent," Mara said, and the word made her laugh once, small and broken. "It doesn't get consent."

The train thundered in, wind whipping at their clothes. For a second the platform blurred into motion - faces, phones, glowing ads. Mara caught sight of the QR tag again, flashing on a billboard for a streaming service, the white square pulsing in time with the station's vibration.

The tag looked like a piece of the meme, like the same square logic, the same invitation.

Mara yanked her wrist free and moved fast. She opened her messaging app, then her settings, then her connection permissions, her fingers moving on a kind of frantic muscle memory she didn't trust. She could feel the heat of the phone against her palm, even through the case.

Her stomach dropped when she saw it: "Auto-send suggested links: Enabled."

She hadn't enabled it. She was sure. She'd never liked that feature. She'd turned it off months ago after a scam link had tried to masquerade as a delivery update.

Now it was back.

Ethan leaned in, voice tight. "It's rewriting."

Mara forced herself to focus on the only thing that mattered - prevent the tag from landing in more places. She killed the auto-send toggle. She blocked unknown links. She turned off her mobile data.

The phone screen dimmed, then brightened again. A new notification slid down like a tongue.

"Message sent."

Mara's breath left her. She didn't remember pressing send.

She turned the phone toward Ethan. The chat thread with Tessa Nolan sat there, the last message stamped with a timestamp.

Seen. Read receipt.

Tessa's name looked innocent on the screen. The small circle next to it felt like an eye.

Ethan didn't touch the phone. He just stared. "She got it."

Mara's mouth went dry. "No." Her voice cracked on the single syllable. "I stopped it."

"You cancelled the draft," Ethan said, careful, as if the words themselves might break something. "But it had already pushed the link through."

Mara tried to picture Tessa standing in her kitchen, staring at her own phone, smiling at a meme because that's what Tessa did when the world felt heavy. Tessa had always been the one who sent jokes at midnight. Tessa had always been the one who didn't believe in monsters until they wore familiar faces.

Mara's own face felt like a mask suddenly, like something she'd been wearing without noticing. She lifted her phone slightly, and for a blink she saw the distorted outline of herself in the glass - eyes that weren't quite aligned, a mouth that held a shape she didn't recognize. The station's fluorescent lights made it worse, turning her reflections into a series of almost-rights.

Ethan's voice drew her back. "We still have time. We can warn her - "

"Warn her how?" Mara's hands shook. "She'll open it. She'll see the tag. She'll think it's a joke. Or - " Her mind snagged on the response video, on her face moving without sound. "Or it'll already know what she'll do."

The platform roared as another train slid past, and the wind shoved stale air into Mara's lungs. She tasted grime and something sweet underneath, like overheated plastic.

Mara looked around, searching for anything that felt like control. People were holding their phones up to the ads. Two teenagers laughed as a QR scan chimed on one of their screens. A woman in a scarf tilted her head toward a billboard, thumb hovering, waiting for the tag to confirm it had latched on.

Systemic. Not just one uploader. Not just one account. It was everywhere at once, built into the rhythm of the city.

Mara's phone buzzed again with a fresh message notification - this time not a draft, but an outgoing link preview already queued in her thread with Tessa. The sender line read as if Mara had typed it. Her name sat there like proof.

Ethan's face went pale. "It's using your identity."

Mara's mind went cold in a way that felt different from panic. Panic was loud. This was quiet, like the moment before glass shatters. She understood, finally, why the dead phone's future photo had felt warm. It wasn't just a warning. It was a demonstration. The meme wasn't waiting for her to cooperate.

It was already inside her routines, inside her permissions, inside the way her phone decided what came next.

Mara lunged toward the station's information kiosk, the kind with a screen and a keypad and a speaker that always sounded slightly too far away. She jabbed at the touch screen until it responded, then tried to log in to the carrier account with her credentials.

The kiosk rejected her. "Authentication failed."

"Of course," she hissed.

Ethan grabbed her elbow. "Mara. Don't get stuck here."

"I have to stop it from sending." She pressed her thumb against the phone's settings again, trying to find any emergency route. "If it's already pushed to Tessa, I can at least stop it from spreading further."

Ethan's gaze flicked to her face - again, that wordless checking, like he was afraid of what he might see. "Then do it fast."

Mara didn't argue. She opened her accounts: social app, messaging app, browser history, every place her contacts lived. Her fingers moved with a mechanical steadiness that didn't feel like hers. She disabled permissions. She revoked access. She deleted the link previews in her history, even though they reappeared seconds later like something living under the surface.

Her phone kept trying to reconnect, kept offering suggestions, kept trying to slide the meme link into her world with the casual confidence of a notification.

A man in a flannel shirt walked past, bumping her shoulder. "Sorry," he mumbled, then smiled at his own screen like it was a joke he couldn't wait to share.

Mara snapped her head toward him. His eyes were bright, pupils too wide. He wasn't looking at her; he was looking at his phone and the ad tags blinking

above.

He didn't react to her fear. He didn't react to the way she was watching him.

The meme had learned the timing of distraction.

Ethan's grip tightened. "Mara - "

She made a decision that felt like ripping off a bandage with her teeth. She hit "Disable account" on the social app first, then messaging. She turned on airplane mode to cut the phone's lifeline, then immediately turned it back off to force a new connection. The screen flashed. The phone vibrated like it was resisting.

She watched her own profile picture - her altered face on the burner feed - spin into a loading icon, then blur into something else for a second, like the system couldn't decide what version of her it should be.

The station noise swelled. Mara felt sweat cool along her spine. Her ears rang with the train's passing vibration.

Then the outgoing messages stopped.

For one breath, the phone went quiet.

Ethan let out a breath that sounded like relief and grief braided together. "Okay," he said. "Okay. It's not sending anymore."

Mara stared at the screen, waiting for the next buzz, waiting for the meme to find a new loophole in the seconds she'd just bought.

Instead, her phone displayed one final notification, simple and cruel.

"1 viewed."

The timestamp sat beneath it, close enough to the moment she'd tried to cancel the draft.

Mara's stomach clenched so hard she thought she might vomit. The viewed indicator didn't list content. It didn't explain anything. It just confirmed what her eyes already refused to accept.

Tessa had opened it.

Mara looked up from the phone to the platform crowd. The QR tags still flashed on ads. People still scanned. The system kept moving without her permission, without her consent.

She couldn't stop the wave by deleting an app. She couldn't choke the city's appetite with a settings toggle.

What she could do was cut her own route out of it, deny it her access, and pray that her closest friend could survive the version of her face that the meme insisted on rewriting.

Ethan read the expression on Mara's face and went still. "How long ago?"

"Just now," Mara whispered. The words felt like ash. "She opened it."

Ethan's eyes flicked toward the nearest ad screen, where the QR square pulsed in steady rhythm. "Then it's already inside her," he said, more certainty than he should've had.

Mara didn't answer. She pictured Tessa's hands, Tessa's laugh, Tessa's habit of sending things without thinking. She pictured her friend's reflection changing in small increments, the way Mara's had, the way it had been creeping into her memory until she couldn't tell which was real.

A cold certainty settled behind Mara's ribs: even if she stopped the spread through her accounts, the meme had already jumped. It didn't need her permission once it had a foothold.

She tightened her grip on the phone until her knuckles ached, then slid it into her pocket as if she could physically hide the danger. Her other hand found the

strap of her bag, fingers digging in, grounding her to the present.

Around them, the platform kept humming with glowing screens and casual laughter. No one screamed. No one ran. The citywide tagging wave moved like weather, indifferent to who it touched.

As the train doors opened with a wet hiss, Mara watched people spill forward, phones still lit, scanning still chiming. Ethan leaned close enough that his shoulder brushed hers, steadying her against the press of bodies.

"Come on," he said. "We have to find her."

Mara stepped toward the train, feeling the vibration travel through the soles of her shoes. The air tasted like metal and electricity. Somewhere behind her pocket, her phone stayed dark, but she could still feel its presence like a bruise.

She didn't know what Tessa looked like right now. She didn't know what the meme had decided her friend's face should become.

But Mara knew the worst part with a clarity sharp enough to cut: she could disable her accounts and block outgoing messages, and it would still be too late for the people closest to her.

The wave had already reached them.

And as the crowd surged onto the train, Mara realized she wasn't just trying to stop viewers anymore.

She was trying to outrun the changes the meme had already started, before they finished writing the next version of someone she loved.



Tessa's Last Unsent Message

The lobby light in Tessa's building flickered like it was trying to remember how to stay on. Mara stood at the top of the stairwell landing with her phone clenched so tight her thumbnail hurt, the screen still bright with the viral meme livestream she'd tried to kill on her own device hours ago. It had already moved past that - past her blocks, past her panic - because the contacts list on her phone had started lighting up with names she recognized like a roll call.

Tessa Nolan was there. Not as a message thread. Not as a call attempt. Just as a contact with a fresh viewing tag beside it, timestamped after the moment Mara's hands had been shaking enough to drop everything she'd grabbed at the urgent care. Mara could still hear the physician assistant's polite skepticism, the way the nurse had glanced at her photos like they were a prank. She could still feel the dead phone in her pocket, heavier than it should've been, warm as if it had been held against skin.

Down the hallway, someone's footsteps thudded and then stopped. The silence that followed was too clean, too deliberate, like the building was listening.

Mara thumbed the screen until it went dark, then opened it again, as if repetition might make the tag disappear. The meme didn't care about her attempts to deny it. It showed up in her history anyway - an endless little loop of the same distorted face, the same slow drift, the same way the livestream's audio kept crawling under her thoughts. When she stared hard enough, she could almost see the moment it had reached out and taken hold of other people's attention. She couldn't see Tessa's face, not directly, but she could see the consequence: her friend had watched.

"I'm not late," Mara said, and the words sounded wrong in her own ears. Like they belonged to someone who hadn't already watched herself change.

She pushed off the wall and started down the stairs two at a time, the concrete steps cold through the thin soles of her shoes. Her breath came hard, loud in the stairwell. The air was stale with old laundry and something metallic that made her tongue feel dry. Her phone buzzed once in her grip, a vibration like a warning. A new contact tag appeared - someone from her work group chat, someone she hadn't spoken to in months - and Mara's stomach turned as if the meme had reached under her ribs and found a loose wire.

Ethan had been right about one thing: it wasn't just sending. It was already there, already in the motion of people's screens and minds. She'd wanted to believe she could catch it like a runaway app, close the window, call it done. Now she was running toward the only person who mattered, and the fear in her chest was stitched together with guilt so sharp it felt physical.

Because she hadn't been careful enough.

Because she'd watched it first.

Because she'd thought she could stop it before it touched Tessa, like speed could rewrite an infection.

Mara reached the lobby. The doors were glass, scuffed with fingerprints and old stickers. The front desk was empty; a "Back Soon" sign lay face-down as if someone had flipped it away in a hurry. The security camera dome on the ceiling tilted slightly, or maybe Mara's eyes did, because everything felt unsteady now - her thoughts, her balance, the way the lobby light made the edges of her hands look slightly off, like a video compression artifact.

She scanned the directory on the wall, breath fogging faintly on the glass of the letters. Tessa's last name was easy to find. Everyone knew where she lived. Everyone had visited at least once; Mara could picture the way Tessa's

apartment smelled like citrus cleaner and warm bread from the corner bakery, could picture her laugh when her cat knocked a cup off the counter.

Could picture. That was the problem. Mara's mind kept supplying memories with confidence that didn't feel earned.

She dug her phone out again, the screen lighting her palm. Her contact list scrolled like it was eager to show her the damage. There was Tessa's name, and beside it, a tag that hadn't been there yesterday.

Mara's throat tightened. She reached for the building intercom with her free hand, thumb hovering over the call button. The plastic was slick with fingerprints. Her skin stuck briefly, then released with a faint squeak.

She pressed.

The intercom crackled. Static hissed over itself, then - nothing. Not even the usual automated greeting. Mara tried again, harder, as if brute force could force a response out of a machine. Static. A short burst of audio that sounded like a muted laugh distorted through a wall. Then silence again, thicker than before.

"Mara?" a voice said behind her.

She spun so fast her shoulder popped. Ethan stood in the doorway, rain-dark hair plastered to his forehead, wearing the same hoodie she'd seen him in the last time they'd tried to outrun this. His eyes were red-rimmed, and he looked too tired for the speed at which they'd been moving. He held his phone at his side like he was afraid it might bite him.

"You - " Mara started, then stopped because the word she wanted to say was wrong. She didn't know if she was relieved or furious that he'd followed her. She didn't know how to be anything but terrified.

Ethan's gaze flicked to her phone, then away. "I tried calling. It didn't go through. And then my feed..." His voice wavered on the edge of a laugh that

didn't reach his mouth. "My feed started showing her as viewed. Like it was... like it was already done."

Mara's fingers curled around her phone until her knuckles ached. "It's not done," she said. "She's - she'll be in there."

Ethan stepped closer, careful, as if any sudden movement might trigger something. "Mara." He said her name like a plea. "Your face - "

The lobby glass caught her reflection, and Mara flinched. Her eyes went to it before she could stop herself. The woman in the reflection didn't look like the woman Mara remembered being. It wasn't a dramatic transformation - no sudden gore, no cartoon distortion. It was worse than that. It was small, subtle, the kind of change that made doubt feel like a second illness. The skin at her cheekbone looked slightly smoother than it should've, as if the surface had been re-drawn. Her mouth sat with a different tension, her lips not quite where Mara expected them to be.

She raised her hand to her face. Her fingers felt normal. Her reflection didn't match the sensation.

"What?" Ethan asked softly.

Mara lowered her hand, forcing her voice steady. "It changed again. I know it did." Even as she said it, a thought slithered in: What if the meme wasn't changing her? What if it was changing what she believed she was? The urgent care photos had shown one thing. Her memory had insisted on another. Her dead phone had shown a future that her mind refused to accept.

She couldn't afford to lose herself completely. Not when Tessa might already be losing her.

Ethan swallowed. "Come on. We can go up."

Mara turned toward the stairwell. The building's carpet swallowed their footsteps with a muffled thud. The air got warmer as they climbed, the temperature rising by degrees that felt like they'd been added by someone's breath. The walls were scuffed and painted over so many times they looked bruised.

At each landing, the lobby light flickered in a different rhythm. The sound of it - electric flutter, then steadier hum - felt like a heartbeat she couldn't synchronize with her own.

Mara reached Tessa's floor and found a new strip of tape on the stairwell wall. It wasn't there last time. It was clean, bright white, like it had been placed yesterday. A small tag was written on it in black marker: a crude symbol that looked like a camera shutter and a mouth shape fused together. Beneath it, someone had scribbled the meme's name.

Mara's stomach dropped. She stared at the marker strokes until the letters blurred. Her mind tried to tell her she'd never seen this tag before, but her body reacted like it had been waiting.

Ethan stepped beside her. "Did you - ?" he began.

"No," Mara said too fast. She touched the tape. It was warm. Not sun-warmed. Warm like skin.

Ethan's phone buzzed again. He glanced down and went pale in a way that made Mara's own fear feel justified. He held the screen out slightly, like he didn't trust his eyes.

A viewing tag.

Tessa's name.

But this time, the timestamp was closer - closer than it should've been, considering how hard they'd been running. It felt like the meme was catching up

to their movement. Like it had hands.

Mara backed away from the tape. The stairwell smelled faintly of bleach over something older, like damp paper. Her ears filled with a low, constant electrical whine that she hadn't noticed until now. She pressed her palm against the wall to ground herself, and her skin came away slightly slick, as if the paint were sweating.

"I have to get to her door," Mara said.

Ethan's mouth opened, then closed. He looked like he wanted to argue, like he wanted to say stopping would be smarter. But he didn't. He nodded once, hard, and followed her down the hall.

Tessa's unit door was at the end. The hallway light above it hummed and flickered, making the paint look wet. Mara's keyring felt too heavy against her hip. She fumbled it once, then managed to pull the correct key out. The metal was cold, and it steadied her fingers for a second.

She raised her hand to knock.

The door opened.

Not all the way. Just a crack, enough for a line of dark air to slide out. The silence behind it was thick, the kind of quiet that came after sound had been swallowed rather than absent.

"Mara?" Ethan whispered behind her.

Mara didn't answer. Her eyes went to the doorway threshold. There was no sign of struggle. No blood. No dropped shoes. Just a faint smear on the lower edge of the door, like someone had dragged their palm through dust.

Mara leaned closer. The air that slipped out smelled wrong - warm plastic, stale coffee, and something that reminded her of overheated electronics. Her skin prickled.

"Hello?" she called, voice rough.

No reply.

She pushed the door wider with her shoulder. The hinge squealed, a thin sound that seemed too small for the dread pressing against her. The hallway light spilled in, caught on nothing for a second - just dim carpet and the edge of a couch.

Then Mara saw the wall.

On the inside of the entryway, where a family photo frame should've been, there was a fresh meme tag. The same shutter-mouth symbol, drawn larger, ink darker, as if whoever marked it had been closer to the writing hand. Under it, a new phrase had been scrawled in shaky letters that looked like they'd been written in panic.

Mara's eyes snagged on her own name.

Not "Mara Ellison," not the full thing. Just Mara. Like the meme didn't need the rest. Like it had already picked out the part of her identity it could rewrite.

Her vision tunneled. She heard Ethan's breath catch. She heard something else too, faint and rhythmic, coming from deeper inside the apartment. A soft tapping, like nails against glass, like someone pressing a phone repeatedly against a surface.

"Mara," Ethan said again, and this time his voice sounded like fear disguised as concern. "Stop."

Mara didn't stop. She stepped forward, the carpet under her shoes feeling wrong - too springy, like the fibers were layered. Her phone buzzed in her hand, and for a moment she thought it was just another viewing update. But the screen lit on its own anyway, like a switch flipping in a dark room.

The viral meme livestream was open.

Not a link she'd tapped. Not something she'd pulled up. It was already there, already playing, already showing the distorted face in motion.

The sound was muted, but the image alone made her stomach roll. The face on the screen wasn't exactly hers, not anymore than it had been before. It was close enough that her brain tried to reconcile it, tried to decide which version was the real one. The meme's distortions looked like they were adjusting in response to her focus, like it could feel her attention.

Mara clutched the phone and backed toward the doorway. She tried to close the app. Her thumb moved, but the screen didn't respond the way it should. The livestream kept playing, the image shifting, the shutter-mouth symbol flickering in the corner like a watermark.

"Mara," Ethan said, louder. "She's not - "

The tapping sound stopped.

Silence snapped into place so hard Mara felt it in her teeth. Then, from somewhere in the apartment, a sound came that wasn't a voice but could've been one: a breath dragged through fabric, a soft shudder that made her skin crawl.

Mara turned her head toward the living room.

A shape stood there in the dimness, half-lit by the hallway light. For one terrible second, Mara's mind insisted it was Tessa. The posture was right. The height was right. Even the way the shoulders sat - like someone bracing against cold - felt familiar in the way memories sometimes do when they're trying to protect you.

Then the shape moved, and Mara saw the error.

The face was wrong. Not grotesquely wrong - wrong in a way that made her stomach seize. Features that should've lined up didn't. The mouth sat too tight,

the eyes too open, the skin too smooth in patches like fresh plastic. The head tilted with a precision that didn't belong to a person.

It wasn't Tessa Nolan anymore.

Or maybe it was Tessa with her humanity stripped down to something the meme could wear.

Mara's throat worked but no sound came out. Her body felt like it was waiting for permission to panic.

Ethan grabbed her arm, hard enough to hurt. "Mara. Don't - don't look at it."

"I have to - " Mara began, because she couldn't stand the idea of not knowing. She couldn't stand the idea that the last thing she'd do for Tessa was flee.

The shape in the living room lifted one hand. Its fingers trembled, then steadied, like it had learned stillness from watching videos. The hallway light caught the phone in its grip - her phone, or a phone like it, held at an angle that made the screen visible from where Mara stood.

On the screen, the meme's symbol pulsed.

And beside it, a fresh tag appeared.

Viewed.

Mara's own name.

Ethan's grip tightened until Mara's arm threatened to bruise. "Mara," he said again, voice breaking. "It's done. It's - "

Mara tried to make her eyes leave the screen. Tried to blink and clear the image. Her reflection in the dark phone screen looked back at her in fragments - cheekbone, mouth, eyes - each piece shifting just enough to keep her from anchoring herself.

A sob scraped up her throat and turned into something uglier, something she couldn't swallow. She felt the grief first, like a wave hitting before she understood where it came from. Not grief for a person she could still reach, but grief for the version of her friend that had existed before the meme got its hands on her.

Mara stumbled backward into the doorway, knocking her shoulder against the frame. The cold wood jolted her into awareness. She shoved Ethan aside just enough to get her own door key out again, fumbling with shaking fingers.

The shape in the living room didn't move toward her. It didn't need to. It stood there as if it had all the time in the world. As if the apartment itself had become a stage.

When Mara finally managed to pull the key free, her hand brushed the wall beside the threshold.

More tape.

Not just one tag now. Another white strip had been added, fresh ink bleeding into the paint like it was still wet. This one wasn't written in marker. It looked like it had been printed, crisp and clean, the letters too perfect for a human hand.

Mara stared at it until her eyes watered.

Her name again.

Under it, a timestamp.

Minutes ago.

She couldn't breathe without tasting static. Her mind tried to insist she was misreading, tried to insist the marker was just ink, the timestamp just a trick, the warmth just the building's wiring. But her body already knew. Her phone already knew. Her reflection in the dark screen had already decided.

Mara opened the stairwell door and stepped into the hallway like she could outrun what had happened inside by leaving the room behind. The hallway light flickered once, then steadied, and that small normalcy felt like a lie.

Ethan followed her out, pulling the door closed with careful hands. The click sounded final. Mara pressed her back to the wall beside the unit number, staring at the closed door as if staring could unwrite the moment.

Her phone buzzed again.

She looked down.

A new tag wasn't for Tessa anymore. It was for the building lobby - somehow, somewhere - tagged as viewed. The meme didn't need a person's eyes anymore. It could mark spaces. It could move through attention and leave proof behind.

Mara's reflection in the hallway's glossy paint looked back at her, and this time it felt like the person inside the reflection was wearing her face without asking permission. The features were shifting faster than her mind could catalogue. The proof she'd relied on was becoming just another moving target.

She swallowed hard, then dragged in a breath that tasted like old carpet and static.

On the stairwell wall behind her, the fresh meme tag waited in the dim light, warm under the paint as if it had been placed seconds ago.

Mara stared until her eyes blurred, and in the blur she could almost see the next version of herself arriving - already tagged, already viewed - before she could decide whether she was the one who'd been watching or the one being watched.



The Response Video in the Dark

Mara's knuckles hit the stairwell door so hard the metal rang through the landing, and the sound didn't fade - didn't travel right. It kept looping, thin and wrong, like the building itself had learned the meme's rhythm. She shoved the door open anyway, dragging air behind her with the smell of old paint and damp concrete, and hurried down the service corridor that ran behind the café. Ethan's earlier text - *I'm with you* - glowed on her phone and then flickered, as if the screen couldn't decide whether it was being viewed or used.

The tag on her phone pulsed once, then again. Not a notification. A heartbeat.

Tessa's building had been quiet when Mara arrived, quiet in the way a room goes quiet when someone stops breathing. No voice through the intercom. No neighbor gossiping. No music from behind a door. Just the fresh meme-mark waiting in the stairwell paint, warm under the skin of the wall like someone had pressed their palm there. Mara had stared until her eyes burned, until she could almost see the next version of herself crossing the lobby at the exact moment she chose not to believe her own eyes.

Now, in the corridor behind the café, she found the utility room door cracked open.

Light spilled through the gap - computer light, server-light - too steady for the building that held it. Mara shoved the door wider with her shoulder, and the hinges complained like they'd been trained to imitate pain. The room was narrow and black with cables. Behind a bank of equipment, a monitor stood on a folding table as if it belonged there, as if someone had carried it in and set it down

carefully. The screen showed the meme livestream in a bright, grainy frame that made her stomach seize: her own face, pale and half-tilted, staring out of a camera that wasn't in the room.

Except it wasn't her face the way she remembered it. It was the way it had started to look in reflections - slightly too symmetrical, like the world had corrected her without asking. The mouth was moving in small, delayed motions. The eyes didn't blink on a human schedule.

A sound came from the monitor - soft, like a finger dragging across cloth - and the looped stairwell ring synced with it. Mara's throat tightened. She could taste copper, the same metallic tang that rose in her mouth when she watched the livestream too long.

The phone in her hand vibrated. The screen went dark, then lit again with a new tag overlaying Tessa's building address, even though Mara was standing in the café's back hall. The meme was reaching across space like it had already mapped the distances.

Her goal sharpened into something immediate and ugly: break the broadcast, find the mechanism, make it stop choosing people like a lottery. If it could hijack screens and trap the air around them in a loop, then somewhere in this room there was a source - an output, a power line, a device that fed the livestream into the world until it became unavoidable.

Mara backed into the room, keeping her body between the monitor and the hallway. Her shoulder brushed a bundle of cables; they were warm, not from the building's aging heat but from current. Electricity had a smell when it was too close - hot plastic and a faint ozone bite that made her eyes water.

"Ethan?" she called, but her voice sounded muffled, as if the room had cotton in its ears.

No answer. Just the monitor's grainy hiss and the dragging finger sound, repeating.

Mara moved toward the table. The older camera she kept for plant cuttings thumped against her hip as she hurried, a ridiculous weight in a place that smelled like burned dust. She didn't pull it out. She needed the source. She needed the feed.

The monitor's frame shifted. The livestream image brightened as though someone had adjusted the exposure. Her distorted face on-screen leaned forward, and for a moment the delay between her mouth movement and the audio tightened until it felt like she was hearing herself breathe.

Then the screen flickered, and the meme's uploader - no, not an uploader, because the face wasn't a person any longer - displayed a plain black rectangle with white text that wasn't typed so much as pressed through a glitch.

VIEWER-LOCKED.

The words weren't there long enough to read twice, but Mara's mind caught them anyway, like a hook snagging fabric. Her phone buzzed again. The camera app on her phone opened by itself, the lens icon hovering as if someone had held her finger there.

"Mara," Ethan's voice finally came through her earbuds - thin, distorted, like it had traveled through the monitor's hiss before reaching her. "The network - everything's... it's mirroring. Don't - "

His sentence cut off with a pop. The earbuds went quiet.

Mara swallowed hard and forced herself to look away from the monitor, away from the face that kept rearranging itself into something the world seemed ready to accept. She turned to the server closet wall where a power strip and cables ran under a metal shelf. The utility room wasn't just a room; it was a spine. If she cut the spine, maybe the meme would lose its nerve.

Her phone vibrated again. This time it wasn't a tag. It was a message preview, though she hadn't heard any typing sounds.

You're already watching. You always were.

The bubble didn't have an account name. Just a blank circle where a profile picture should have been.

Mara's stomach rolled. She remembered Tessa's unsent message, the last time she'd tried to contact her and found silence. She remembered the stairwell tag sitting warm under paint like it had been placed seconds ago. She remembered how her trust in her own eyes had started to collapse in Hawthorne Urgent Care when the nurse stared at her printed photos and called them "old."

She couldn't afford to doubt herself now. Doubt was what the meme fed on.

Mara grabbed the power strip cable with both hands. It was thicker than she expected, braided like someone had tried to make it harder to pull loose. The insulation felt slightly tacky, as if it had been handled recently.

As she yanked, the room shuddered. Not the building's normal groan - something more deliberate. The monitor's image stuttered, then snapped back with sharper clarity, like it had been waiting for resistance.

Her distorted face on-screen smiled without moving her cheeks.

The monitor's audio spiked - too loud for the small speakers - and then she heard something else layered under it: the sound of a notification chime, repeating, repeating, repeating. Mara's phone screen lit in her palm, and the meme livestream began to play there too, even though she'd never tapped anything.

Tessa's face appeared in the phone's grainy frame. Not her current face, not the last one Mara had seen at her own kitchen table. This was Tessa as the meme was writing her into existence - eyes slightly off, mouth pulling toward a shape that didn't match her own memory. Tessa's head turned like she was responding to sound from inside the glass.

"Mara," the phone said, but it wasn't Tessa's voice. It was the same dragging-finger hiss shaped into speech. The syllables landed wrong, too smooth, like a voice imitating grief.

Mara froze, hands still on the cable. The power strip cable resisted her pull with a jerk that almost threw her forward. For a second she thought the meme had physically tethered the strip to the feed, like it could weld itself into the wiring.

Her goal stayed the same, but the obstacle thickened: cutting the power wasn't just turning off a device. It was interrupting something that had already spread beyond the room, beyond the monitor. The message on the phone wasn't a threat. It was a demonstration.

If Mara cut the source, the meme would cut back.

"Mara!" Ethan's voice returned, louder this time, crackling through the earbuds as if he'd dragged himself closer to the signal. "It's - there's a second feed. It's coming from the café's back router. I can see it in the logs, but the screen keeps... looping."

Mara didn't have time to argue with him. She needed to know where the power actually connected. The server closet wall had a panel with three labels she couldn't read well under the flicker. She reached for it anyway.

The moment her fingers touched the panel, the room temperature dropped. Cold seeped into her wrists like water down a sleeve. The smell of ozone sharpened until it made her eyes sting. The monitor's grain tightened into a perfect, brutal stillness.

Her distorted face leaned closer to the camera, and the eyes on-screen seemed to track Mara's motion even though she hadn't moved the monitor. The viewer-locked words flashed again, briefly replacing the grain with a clean white-on-black frame.

INTERRUPT COST: FINALIZE.

The cable in her hands went slack, then snapped back as if yanked from the other end. Mara yelped, stumbling. She nearly fell into the cable rack, and her older camera clacked against metal, the sound sharp enough to cut through the looped chime.

In the phone screen, the meme image of Tessa shivered. Her mouth opened, and for a second Mara heard something like a real breath - short, wet, human. Then the screen cut to Mara's own face again, and her mouth on-screen moved in sync with the audio as if the meme had found a way to match her timing.

Mara's pulse hammered against her throat. She pulled the power strip free with a hard, deliberate jerk, not caring if it tore the cable. The monitor didn't go dark.

Instead, it dimmed, then flared, and the livestream continued - still playing - while the room's lights flickered and died. Emergency bulbs buzzed once, then steadied. The monitor's hiss changed pitch like it was drawing power from somewhere else.

The broadcast wasn't just a device on a table. It was a networked loop, self-sustaining in its own way.

Mara backed away from the monitor, breathing shallow to avoid tasting the copper in the air. She looked at the phone in her hand. The tag overlay on Tessa's building address pulsed again, and a new line of text formed under the meme image. It wasn't typed. It bled through the glitch.

VIEWER-LOCKED FORM BEGINS WHEN INTERRUPTED.

Mara's lips parted. "So it can be stopped," she whispered, and the words tasted wrong - like she was swallowing someone else's certainty. "It can be stopped, but - "

Ethan's voice cut in, breathless. "Mara, don't - whatever you're doing, it's happening to you too. I can see your face change on the screen. Like it's - like it's locking. I'm trying to get in, but the doors - "

Mara stared at her reflection in the darkened monitor frame. She could see herself faintly, superimposed over the meme image, the grain turning her features into something her mind didn't want to accept. Her eyes looked too steady. Her mouth looked too determined.

She understood the cost without being told. The meme wasn't only altering viewers while they watched. It was using interruption as a trigger, turning resistance into a final version.

Her hands shook as she reached for the server closet power panel again. Cold crawled up her forearms. The room felt like it was holding its breath in a way she could hear.

Mara made her decision with a clarity that hurt.

She yanked the metal panel open. Inside, wires ran thick and bundled, color-coded and labeled in fading marker - labels meant for maintenance, meant for people who believed systems behaved. Her fingers found the main breaker switch that controlled the cabinet feeding the back router.

The switch was stiff, as if it had been sealed with time. Her palm slid across it, and the surface was slick with condensation that hadn't been there a moment before. She pressed her thumb down anyway.

The monitor flared one last time. On it, her distorted face raised a hand toward the lens. The gesture wasn't animated like a video. It was too deliberate, like an intention.

Mara snapped the breaker down.

The room's hiss died with a suddenness that felt like a knife cutting sound. The monitor went black. For half a second, the air filled with silence so thick it made her ears ring.

Then her phone screen lit again - not with the livestream, but with her reflection.

Not a live camera feed. Not a normal selfie preview. It was a captured image, crisp and timestamped, the kind of photo that would be shared later with a caption that made no sense. Her face in the image already looked finalized - viewer-locked. The cheeks sat differently. The angle of her jaw had shifted into a shape that didn't match her memory, like the meme had used interruption to complete a version it had been drafting for weeks.

The timestamp at the corner read minutes ago.

Mara stared until her eyes watered. Her own breathing sounded too loud in the sudden quiet. When she raised her hand, her fingers moved normally. The skin on her face felt the same - warm, alive - yet the mirror image in the phone refused to agree with her internal map of herself.

Ethan's voice came through the earbuds, faint and distant, like he was shouting into a hallway that had become miles long. "Mara? It's out. The loop - everything's dead. But there's still a feed in your phone. It won't... it won't close."

Mara lifted the phone closer to her face. The viewer-locked form on-screen didn't move. It didn't blink. It didn't need to. It had already been written.

She looked past her own phone screen to the dark utility room. Cables hung like ropes over a cliff. The emergency bulb buzzed softly, steady now, refusing to flicker. No new tag pulsed on Tessa's address.

No new livestream.

For the first time since the stairwell paint had warmed under her stare, the meme's presence felt held back. Not gone. Held.

Mara swallowed. Her throat hurt, and her tongue tasted like pennies. She pressed her thumb against the phone's screen, trying to close it, trying to swipe away the image as if she could dismiss it with motion.

The phone didn't respond.

Instead, the viewer-locked photo shifted - subtly, cruelly - into a different frame. Her face remained finalized, but the angle changed, as though someone had moved the camera behind her eyes.

A new line of text appeared under the image, white-on-black and clean in a way that made Mara's skin crawl.

NOW SELECTING NEXT VIEWER.

The quiet ended with a soft click from somewhere deeper in the server closet. A relay. A switch. Something rerouted itself even without power, like the meme had learned to survive without electricity.

Mara's head snapped toward the sound.

In the black monitor frame, faint reflections returned - tiny, distorted shapes of screens she couldn't see, faces she didn't recognize, all of them angled toward the same point, all of them waiting for a broadcast that was no longer on air.

Mara stood in the dark utility room with her phone locked on her finalized viewer-locked form, and the loop didn't return through the monitor.

It returned through the idea of being watched.

Behind her, the corridor door creaked, slow and deliberate, as if someone had finally found the exact moment to step in.



A New Face, a New Warning

The corridor door behind her creaked, slow and deliberate, as if it had finally found the right rhythm for stepping in. Mara didn't turn. She kept both hands on the utility-room switch panel, knuckles whitening under the harsh worklight that smelled like dust and burnt plastic.

"Don't," a voice said from the doorway - flat, too close to be a stranger, wrong in its familiarity. It wasn't Ethan. It wasn't anyone she could place. It was the kind of warning that sounded rehearsed.

Mara yanked the lever down anyway. The monitor behind the glass flickered, colors stuttering like a bad stream. The distorted livestream of her face - her mouth already misaligned by a fraction, her eyes too dark and too steady - stuttered into static. For a second, the utility-room air went cold, as if the building itself had exhaled.

Then the screen didn't go black. It rewrote itself.

Mara's phone, dead in her palm, vibrated once - more a shiver than a buzz - and the glassy surface of the monitor caught her reflection for a breath. The face looking back wasn't the one she'd been bracing for. It was hers, but the details had been nudged into a version that felt slightly foreign, like an old photograph thumbbed so many times the edges softened. Her lips pressed together and didn't quite match the memory of how they should hold.

The door clicked again. Something moved in the hallway, fabric brushing against the frame. She could hear it: the soft, careful sound of someone trying not to

sound like they were coming closer.

Mara dropped the lever and fumbled for her phone. The screen didn't light. It didn't have to. A thin strip of text crawled across the dead display anyway, faint as condensation: INTERRUPT COST: FINALIZE.

Her throat tightened. "So that's it," she whispered, and the words came out with her voice sounding like it belonged to the wrong shape of her mouth.

The monitor's audio - if it even had audio - crackled. The camera feed wasn't pointed at her anymore. It was pointed at the place her face would be once the meme finished settling. A loading icon rotated in the center of the screen, a cheerful circle that didn't belong in the utility room behind a café.

Mara forced herself to breathe through her nose. She smelled stale coffee grounds and the metallic tang of the burned electronics. She could taste static on her tongue.

She had broken the broadcast loop. That was what the lever had done, what the static had promised. But the cost wasn't just the power. It was her.

And somewhere in the building, in the hallway that now felt like a throat closing, the meme had decided it could still steer the next moment.

Mara looked down at the phone in her hand. The dead screen reflected her new face back at her, and the reflection wouldn't align with what she remembered seeing in mirrors. She tried to blink it into agreement. Her eyelids didn't feel like they belonged to the same person they used to.

She couldn't stop the meme from rewriting her. But she could still do something else. She could put a warning into the world before it found the next set of eyes to target.

Ethan had been right about one thing, even if he didn't know it yet: the meme didn't just alter. It tracked. It followed intent. It punished denial by rewriting the

denial itself.

If she could make a warning that didn't rely on her face being trusted - if she could make it reliable even with a stranger's mouth - then maybe it could disrupt whatever targeting behavior the meme used.

Mara pushed past the utility-room door and into the narrow corridor. The air changed immediately, cooler and damp, with the smell of cleaning solution hiding something older underneath. Her shoes scuffed on the floor. The sound made her flinch - too loud, too real.

In the dim light at the end of the hallway, the man in flannel shirt stood with his back half-turned, as if he'd been waiting there and pretending he wasn't. The woman with scarf hovered near the corner, her posture tight, eyes fixed on Mara like she was a screen that had finally loaded.

"You cut it," the man said. His voice had an edge of relief that made Mara's skin crawl. "Good."

"Good?" Mara heard herself. The new syllables tasted wrong. She stared at him until her eyes burned. "You're the one who - "

His smile didn't reach his eyes. "I'm not the uploader. I'm just... around. Like you were."

Mara's hands clenched. She wanted to grab her laptop, wanted to run, wanted to find a way to broadcast something before the meme could fix the warning into uselessness. But the corridor felt thick, as if the air itself had been tagged. Her phone in her palm went warm, a sensation that made no sense for a dead device.

The woman with scarf lifted her chin slightly. "It's locked," she said, and the way she said it made Mara think of doors that couldn't be unlatched. "The face is settled. It won't come back."

Mara swallowed. Her tongue felt too big. "Then I'll speak anyway."

The flannel man took a step closer. The fabric of his shirt shifted with a quiet sound that reminded her of pages turning. "You'll try to tell people not to - "

"I'll tell them what it does," Mara snapped, and the anger steadied her for half a heartbeat. "And I'll tell them how it targets. I'll tell them what to watch for. I'll make it clear."

The woman with scarf's gaze flicked to Mara's phone. "It'll rewrite your message," she murmured.

Mara's stomach sank. "Not if I record it somewhere it can't reach."

She didn't know if that was true. She only knew the meme had to work through networks, through links, through the same pathways it used to tag. If she could isolate the act of uploading - if she could force the warning into a channel that didn't immediately feed the meme's next version - then she might slip the warning through the cracks.

She forced her feet to move. The corridor narrowed as she walked, the walls too close. Somewhere behind her, the utility-room monitor kept flickering, a ghost of her face still trying to load.

She pushed through a side entrance into the community media center. The lobby smelled like old carpet and lemon polish. Fluorescent lights hummed overhead. The kind of place that held workshops and family movie nights. The kind of place the meme had no business in.

A door at the end of the hallway had a faded sign: RECORDING STUDIO. The letters were chipped, the frame scratched. Mara's mind latched onto the idea like a life raft.

She didn't have to be believed. She had to be heard.

Inside the studio booth, the soundproof walls swallowed the outside world. The air was warmer here, stale with electronics and old foam padding. A microphone sat on a stand like a patient, waiting. A laptop was already powered on, screen angled so the light didn't glare into her eyes. She hadn't set it up. She hadn't been in this studio yet.

Her throat tightened again. The meme had been ahead of her, leaving doors open while she ran.

Mara approached the laptop. Her reflection in the screen was wrong in the way mirrors were wrong when you'd slept too long and your face felt like it belonged to someone else. The details had settled into a viewer-locked configuration: her skin tone slightly off, her cheekbones too defined, her mouth held in an expression she didn't remember choosing.

When she touched the trackpad, the cursor moved sluggishly, as if the system had to consider whether it was safe to obey. A draft file was already open. The title bar read something she couldn't remember typing: FINAL WARNING - DO NOT VIEW.

She stared at it until her eyes watered. Then she looked at her own hands. The tremor there wasn't new, but it felt sharper now, like the meme had tightened the screws on her body's ability to lie to itself.

"Who did this?" she whispered.

The laptop speakers crackled once. No voice. Just a hiss like someone breathing into a phone.

Mara stepped closer to the microphone anyway. The booth's foam ate the sound of her movements. Her own breathing sounded too loud in her ears.

She hit record.

The cursor blinked in the draft window, waiting for her to speak. Her mind raced through everything she'd seen: the distorted livestream of her face in the utility room, the dead phone that had shown a future version of her, the way the meme had tagged Tessa's building even after Mara had blocked auto-send, the way it had inserted tags into stairwells like it was planting seeds in concrete.

She wanted to say it all. She wanted to shove the truth into the mic until it couldn't be misunderstood.

But the internal part - the part that had been cracking since the broadcast loop finalized - held her back. She could feel it in the way her new mouth didn't match her thoughts. She could feel it in the way the memory of her own face kept sliding away when she tried to anchor it.

If she spoke wrong, if she explained it in a way the meme could twist, she might end up helping it.

Mara stared at the monitor of the laptop, where the recording meter pulsed faintly like a heartbeat. Her voice would become a file, a file would become a link, a link would become a doorway. The meme wasn't just altering appearances. It was rewriting contexts.

She leaned in until her lips hovered close to the microphone. The foam smelled faintly of sweat and old paint. Her voice came out careful, measured, as if she were trying to thread a needle through her own fear.

"This isn't - " she started, then stopped. The sentence sounded like denial, and denial was what the meme seemed to eat.

She swallowed and tried again. "The tag doesn't need permission," she said, and the words were steady enough to surprise her. "It follows viewing. It follows clicks. It follows whatever carries the link."

The sound of her voice in the booth made her flinch. It sounded like her, but it carried a slight distortion, like playback on a cheap speaker.

Her eyes burned. She forced herself to keep talking, forced herself not to glance at the draft file and see whether the meme had already inserted edits.

"The warning is the only way it stops," she continued, and the moment the sentence formed, she felt the air shift, like the studio itself had registered the claim.

The laptop fan kicked on harder.

A new line appeared in the draft window, typed letter by letter without her touching the keyboard: RELIABLE WARNINGS BREAK TARGETING. THIS IS NOT FOR YOU.

Mara's stomach dropped. The meme could rewrite text too. It could alter her intent.

She reached for the keyboard, then hesitated. If she corrected the line, would it fight back? If she left it, would the warning become something else in the meme's hands?

The flannel man and the woman with scarf weren't visible through the studio's glass, but she could feel them outside the booth like pressure. She could hear a faint scrape, fabric against wall.

Mara made her decision with the kind of clarity that only comes when every option feels dangerous. She stopped trying to sound like the Mara she remembered being. She stopped trying to fight the meme on grammar and phrasing, because it was already inside the language.

Instead, she spoke around it, through it, into the recording like a person laying down a path in the dark.

"Don't open it," she said, and kept her voice flat, no pleading. "If you see a link that looks like it's already watching you, treat it like a trap. Close it. Cut it off. Don't let it reach your feed."

Her mouth twitched as she said it, and for a second she worried she'd slipped into the meme's cadence. Then she remembered the countermeasure she'd accidentally stumbled toward when she disabled auto-send and blocked links - how the meme couldn't finish targeting where those pathways were sealed.

She changed tactics. She didn't describe solutions. She described behavior.

"It tags systems, not just people," she said. "It uses the path the viewing creates. If your message tools are set to resend, it spreads through that motion. If you stop the motion, it can't find the next surface."

The laptop speakers crackled again. The recording meter stuttered, then steadied. The typed line in the draft window stopped updating, as if the meme had paused to consider whether it could overwrite her voice with its own version.

Mara leaned closer. Her reflection in the laptop screen stared back, mouth held in the fixed expression of viewer-locked permanence. She didn't have the luxury of comfort. She only had the microphone, and the chance to make the meme's targeting behavior stumble.

"If you already saw it," she added, "don't send it forward to prove you're okay. Don't test it. Warnings break targeting when they're reliable."

The word reliable felt like a key turning in a lock she didn't understand. Her skin prickled.

She hit stop.

Silence filled the booth, thick and expectant. The studio's foam absorbed the last of her breath. The laptop screen dimmed, then brightened with a status window: UPLOAD IN PROGRESS.

Mara's hands hovered over the keyboard, not touching. She watched the progress bar crawl. Her phone stayed warm in her palm, and she resisted the

urge to look at the dead screen again. She didn't want to see what it predicted this time.

Outside the booth, a sound like a soft knock came from the hallway. Once. Twice. Not the flannel man. Not the woman with scarf. Something else shifting closer, as if the meme had gained patience.

The upload finished with a click so small it was almost nothing. The laptop displayed a link preview, then a confirmation message: WARNING SENT.

Mara exhaled, and the exhale made her feel lighter for half a second, until she realized that relief was the easiest emotion for something like this to punish.

Her dead phone vibrated. This time it didn't buzz like a shiver. It thrummed like a heartbeat.

She glanced down despite herself.

A new tag appeared on the dead display, crisp and pale in the dim light. It should have populated with Mara's new face - should have filled with the next viewer's cue, the next rewrite, the next version queued to spread.

Instead, the tag field was blank.

No image. No distorted face. No creeping text.

Just an empty rectangle where the meme's targeting signature should have been.

Mara's throat tightened with something close to grief, because blankness felt like mercy and also like a trap waiting to be sprung later. She stared at the empty space until her eyes blurred.

The studio door latch clicked. Through the glass, the flannel man's silhouette shifted. The woman with scarf stood too still, her scarf edge unmoving as if she was holding her breath.

Mara didn't wait for them to speak. She backed away from the microphone, slow, careful, her steps cushioned by the booth's foam-lined floor. Her reflection in the laptop screen still looked wrong, still carried the viewer-locked permanence. She wasn't cured. The meme had already won that part.

But it had lost something else.

She looked at the dead phone again. The blank tag didn't fill. It didn't rewrite itself. It just sat there, inert, like a mouth held open without air.

Mara's lungs warmed with another breath. Her voice came out barely above the booth's hum when she spoke, not into the mic this time, but to the air.

"It can't find the next one," she said.

The hallway sounded closer, footsteps or fabric or the meme itself pretending to be physical. The studio lights flickered once, then steadied. The laptop stayed on, the warning file still listed as sent.

Mara held her phone tighter until her knuckles hurt. The pain grounded her in a body she didn't fully recognize.

Outside, the world continued to move - people scrolling, sending, clicking. The meme would try again. It always would. It was built to be persistent.

But for the first time since she'd pulled the lever down and watched her face rewrite itself, the meme's next tag remained empty.

A warning had slipped through the targeting web.

And Mara, altered and fixed in place, had managed to give it something it couldn't immediately correct.

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The Meme That Changes You

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